

Conquest
or
a Piece of Jade

by
Marie C. Stopes

pgdp.net

Conquest
or
a Piece of Jade

by
Marie C. Stopes

pgdp.net

COVER IMAGE CREATED BY TRANSCRIBER AND PLACED IN THE PUBLIC DOMAIN

The Project Gutenberg eBook of Conquest; Or, A Piece of Jade; a New Play in Three Acts

This eBook is for the use of anyone anywhere in the United States and most other parts of the world at no cost and with almost no restrictions whatsoever. You may copy it, give it away or re-use it under the terms of the Project Gutenberg License included with this eBook or online at www.gutenberg.org. If you are not located in the United States, you will have to check the laws of the country where you are located before using this eBook.

Title: Conquest; Or, A Piece of Jade; a New Play in Three Acts

Author: Marie Carmichael Stopes

Release date: July 5, 2014 [eBook #46198]

Most recently updated: October 24, 2024

Language: English

Other information and formats: www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/46198

Credits: E-text prepared by Henry Flower and the Online Distributed Proofreading Team (<http://www.pgdp.net>) from page images generously made available by Internet Archive (<https://archive.org>)

*** START OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK CONQUEST;
OR, A PIECE OF JADE; A NEW PLAY IN THREE ACTS ***

The Project Gutenberg eBook, Conquest, by Marie Carmichael Stopes

Note: Images of the original pages are available through Internet Archive. See <https://archive.org/details/conquestorpieceo00stop>

CONQUEST

OR

A PIECE OF JADE

A New Play in Three Acts by
MARIE C. STOPES
D.Sc., Ph.D., F.R.S.Litt., etc.

1/- net

COPYRIGHT 1917 BY DR. MARIE C. STOPES

New York
SAMUEL FRENCH
Publisher
28-30 West 38th Street

London
SAMUEL FRENCH, Ltd.
26 Southampton Street
Strand

1917

LEATHERHEAD, SURREY,
ENGLAND.

DEAR MR. DELIGHTFULEST-MANAGER-IN-THE-WORLD,—

I am sending you this play printed instead of type-written because I think you will find it much easier to slip into your pocket and read, and also because I don't know your address, and printed books have a way of finding people without being addressed which typescripts have not yet learnt. So instead of sending my play round, in what people tell me is the usual way, to lots and lots of managers in typescript and wasting ever so much valuable time while they don't read it, I am sending it to you direct, and hope you will like it. When you read it you will find that there is still another reason why I am glad to see it in print.

First let me have just one word in your ear, please: don't look to see how many pages long it is, and (reckoning "a page a minute") say it is too short to fill an evening, for I ought to tell you it is a full-length play but the printer is war-economising and has printed it all on fewer pages than he would have done in the days of Paper, Peace and Plenty long ago.

While I was writing the leading part I pictured one of our finest actresses in it, and she has read it and says the play is "simply splendid": if you want her to take the part I will tell you her name and address, but she is such an angel she will forgive you if some one you love better seems to you to be the heroine.

Yours sincerely,
MARIE C. STOPES.

Registered Copyright by Marie C. Stopes.

The Copyright of CONQUEST is the sole property of the author, to whom application should be made for a license to produce, translate, place on the cinematograph or use in any other way.

*Addressing: DR. MARIE STOPES,
Craigvara, Leatherhead,
Surrey, England.*

“CONQUEST,” or “A PIECE OF JADE.”

A NEW PLAY IN THREE ACTS, BY
MARIE C. STOPES.

TIME: 1915. PLACE: *New Zealand and London.*

ACT I.

An Out-station on the Hyde's Sheep Farm,
New Zealand.
Afternoon.

ACT II.

The Hyde's Homestead, New Zealand.
Morning.
Three or four months elapse between Acts I. and II.

ACT III.

The Duchess of Rainshire's Drawing-room, London.
Evening.
About two months elapse between Acts II. and III.

“CONQUEST,” or “A PIECE OF JADE.”

DRAMATIS PERSONÆ.

In the order of their appearance:

FIRST SHEPHERD.

SECOND SHEPHERD.

GORDON HYDE, *New Zealand Sheep Farmer.*

ROTO, *an old Maori.*

NORA LEE, *A New Zealand Girl.*

LOVEDAY LEWISHAM, *Nora's Cousin, out from England.*

ROBERT HYDE, *New Zealand Sheep Farmer, Gordon's Brother.*

JOHN VARLIE *alias* THE REV DR. CHAPMAN.

RECRUITING OFFICER.

THE DUCHESS OF RAINSHIRE.

A CABINET MINISTER.

SMITHERS.

ALSO (*Without words*):

TWO (OR PERHAPS THREE) YOUNG MEN *in New Zealand Khaki.*

LADIES AND GENTLEMEN, *Guests at the Duchess' Evening Party.*

MAID, *Footman's substitute in uniform.*

TWO PLAIN CLOTHES OFFICERS.

ONE OR TWO COLLIE DOGS.

SHEEP—ONE, OR MORE, *if convenient.*

“CONQUEST,”
OR
“A PIECE OF JADE.”

A NEW PLAY IN THREE ACTS BY
MARIE C. STOPES.

ACT I.

THE SCENE is set in the hills of the sheep-raising part of the S. Island of New Zealand.

The back-cloth is painted with fine rocky and wooded hills and lakes, rather like Scotland but with a clearer, bluer sky and keener atmosphere.

The stage represents a temporary camp in a clearing, for the mustering and marking of sheep. There are boulders and groups of luxuriant trees. The grass is trampled under foot.

RIGHT CENTRE is an open fire with cooking utensils. BACK RIGHT the corner of sheep enclosures. On LEFT is a temporary cover, part canvas, part tree branches.

TWO SHEPHERDS are DISCOVERED near the fire, binding up the leg of a sheep. The collie dogs prowl and lie around.

1ST *(An old, wiry man.)* A fine muster, this year.
SHEP.

2ND *(A dour man, about 45 years old.)* Aye.

SHEP.

1ST The best season I mind for ten years. *(Working with sheep's*
SHEP. *leg.)* Plague take it, it's slipped. Lie still you bleatin' fule ye!
And sheep s'd fetch a guid price this year and all.

2ND Aye.

SHEP.

1ST I'm thinkin' these sheep will be making the fortune of the
SHEP. young masters, but they do nought but make work for us.

2ND *(Spits.)* Aye.

SHEP.

1ST The young masters must get an extra man, we never had to
SHEP. handle so many sheep.

2ND Men'll be scarce now.

SHEP.

1ST They will that. Do you hear they recruitin' fellows are
SHEP. scourin' the country for likely lads?

2ND Aye.

SHEP.

1ST When did you know it?

SHEP.

2ND 'Bout a week ago.

SHEP.

1ST *(Reproachfully.)* And ye kept a tale like that from me—and
SHEP. me that glad of any bit of news in this lonesomeness. I call
that nasty of ye.

(2ND SHEPHERD is silent; spits slowly.)

I call that nasty of ye.

2ND Aye.

SHEP.

1ST And what else do ye know ye might tell me if—if, well, if I
SHEP. had a wee drop of something to loosen your lips—(*Pulls out a flask and a tin cup and pours a small drink—the dogs come up.*) Down Jock—get out Scottie. What news have ye for this, eh?

(2ND SHEPHERD *reaches out his hand.*)

1ST Na-na. News first. It mayn't be worth it all.

SHEP.

2ND The new young lady from England is comin' this afternoon.

SHEP.

1ST What young lady? Why don't I know a' these wild doin's?

SHEP. What's she like. Who's she stayin' with?

2ND Old man Lee and his daughter.

SHEP.

1ST Have you seen her? What's she like?

SHEP.

2ND (*Stretching out his hand for his drink.*) I've earned it.

SHEP.

1ST (*Drawing it away.*) Ye'll tell me what she's like first.

SHEP.

2ND A flower. You give it to me now.

SHEP.

1ST (*Hands it grudgingly.*) Well, perhaps you deserve it. That's

SHEP. news.

(*He slowly fills a kettle out of a pail of water which he observes with annoyance is nearly empty and puts kettle on the fire.*)

For why is she coming here?

2ND London city was killin' her. The doctor ordered six months
SHEP. of healin' air.

1ST If she's as bonny as you say it'll be joyful doings for the
SHEP. young masters. Lasses are scarce here.

2ND There's Nora Lee.
SHEP.

1ST Well, fule. She's only one. We've got two young masters, let
SHEP. alone the other young chaps hereby.

2ND Mister Gordon's lame. What'd he do with a girl?
SHEP.

1ST Only a bit lame, only a wee bit lame, like—and he's got a
SHEP. rare brain—look at the exchange o' reapers and such like he
rigged up for the freeholders around here. He's just chock
full o' ideas and always dreamin' and readin' and talkin'
about 'em. That's what girls like. He'll be as good in a girl's
eyes as his brother—better I shouldn't wonder.

2ND He's no good for the war.
SHEP.

1ST And what matters that? Am I any good for the war? Down
SHEP. Scottie, down will ye! Yourself is not much good for the
war, and yet a pretty girl or two don't come amiss to your
eyes even though they never looked at ye. War! You're crazy
on the war. Why man it's more'n ten thousand miles off and
it's a game for the young chaps anyway.

2ND It's no game.
SHEP.

1ST It'll raise the price of sheep. That's one thing I'm thinking.
SHEP. And we have more sheep on this station to-day than there
have been in my memory. Aren't there now?

2ND Aye.

SHEP.

(GORDON HYDE comes slowly on from right wing, a fishing rod and bag of fish on his shoulder. He is slight, bronzed, and with a fine noble face. He limps, his leg dragging. 1ST SHEPHERD takes up a tin of salmon and slowly begins to prepare to open it.)

GORDO There's a good haul for supper, lads. *(Throws down fish.)*

N.

(THE SHEPHERDS move a little from the fire respectfully, but don't touch their hats or get up.)

1ST Aye, aye, Boss.

SHEP.

(He is just about to insert the tin opener, GORDON suddenly notices him.)

GORDO What have you got there?

N.

1ST A tin of salmon, Boss.

SHEP.

GORDO Stop opening it then. Use that fresh fish instead. Tinned stuff
N. is extra valuable nowadays. It can be sent to the front. We have time to think out here on these hills. I have thought till my head reeled and not yet found out what *big* things we can do for our country, but the little duties are clear enough, and one of 'em is not to be wasteful.

2ND Aye, Boss. That's true.

SHEP.

(1ST SHEPHERD shamefacedly lays down the tin.)

1ST Eh, Boss, the sheep's fine this year.

SHEP.

GORDO What is the full tally?

N.

1ST Mr. Robert hasn't come in yet, but from what I've heard, it

SHEP. looks to be the best year on this station.

GORDO Fine. We can't have too much wool and mutton this year.

N.

(ROTO comes on from left second Entrance, somewhat staggering under two pails of water. He is an old Maori, with straight black hair turning white, and a few tatoo marks on his face. He has high cheek bones, a broad nose, and full lips, but is light brown in colour and very intelligent and fine in expression. He wears a short pair of pants, and a piece of fine matting on his shoulders, his scanty shirt is open at the neck and a string with a carved green jade charm is partly seen.)

ROTO. Here is the water for Miss Nora's tea, Boss.

1ST *(To 2nd Shep.)* She has an healthier thirst than yours.

SHEP.

GORDO *(Busying himself smoothing a seat of fern.)* She'll be tired

N. after that long ride.

1ST The other lady'll be worse. She's not native born like Miss

SHEP. Nora.

GORDO *(Quickly.)* Her fine lady cousin! She's coming, of course. I'd

N. forgotten! Here, you chaps, get that place straight. *(Indicates the shelter, which shows a disorder of blankets, etc.)* What is this sheep doing here?

1ST Her leg broke when she tried to push through over a rocky

SHEP. bit. I have tethered her down. The young lady may like to pat her or tie a ribbon round her neck perhaps.

GORDO *(Grinning.)* You old fool. All right. Leave her. Go and

N. straighten things up a bit in the shelter. 'Tis like a pig-stye.

(A clatter of horses hoofs, shouts of "Whoa there, Nellie. Here we are," etc., is heard without. Two GIRLS with riding hats and whips ENTER front right wing.

NORA LEE is dainty with light hair and a rather sunburnt face and neck. She has pale lashes; she is petite and pretty and rather self-assured. She advances laughing.)

NORA. Here we are!

GORDO *(Springing up and limping hurriedly to meet her, taking off his hat.)* Oh, Nora, I'm glad you've come.

NORA. Where is Robert?

GORDO Out with the men. He'll be back by tea-time.

N.

(LOVEDAY stands a little back looking round and waiting. She is taller than NORA; a splendidly built, dark-haired and beautiful woman, with a clear skin, deep searching eyes, regular features. She walks like a Queen and has a deep-toned, but soft and thrilling voice. She is all in white.)

NORA. This is my cousin, Loveday Lewisham, Gordon.

(LOVEDAY smiles, comes forward and shakes hands with GORDON.)

You know I told you all about her, and how she broke down with war-work in England and is going to make her home with us for six months. *You know.*

GORDO I do know. *(Smiles.)* I wish you welcome, Miss Lewisham.

N.

NORA. Loveday.

GORDO Yes. This is a friendly country. My name is Gordon.

N.

LOVEDAY. How beautiful that view is. And *what* a ride we had. Three hours of fairyland!

NORA. Oh, that's nothing! Let us show her everything. Where's old Roto? She wants to see a Maori. And where is Robert?

GORDO I'll coo-ee for Robert.

N.

(His coo-ee is long and penetrating so that it re-echoes.)

And there is Roto. Hi. Come along, Roto. Miss Nora wants to show you off.

(ROTO advances from shelter, which is now in better order, the blankets piled up, etc.)

ROTO. *(Grinning.)* Here, Miss Nora.

NORA. Good-day, Roto. See, Loveday. This is a real live Maori. Nothing wonderful after all!

LOVED Oh, how do you do?

AY.

ROTO. Finely, Miss.

LOVED *(Smiling winningly.)* You are not nearly so terrifying as I expected!

ROTO. *(Grinning, pleased.)* Maoris not allowed to be terrible now, Miss.

LOVED That is a shame. I'd so *much* rather be a savage myself.

AY. What do you do now they won't let you be a savage any more?

ROTO. Help with the sheep and cook.

LOVED *(Stooping forward and taking hold of ROTO's green jade charm hanging on its long string round his neck.)* And what is that queer thing you wear round your neck?

NORA. *(Hastily.)* A jade charm—these natives often wear them. They are very superstitious.

GORDO The Maoris believe in all sorts of charms and magic and
N. spirits. They have a legend about these forests, for instance,
that a goddess of wisdom lives in these hill tops and is a tree
by day and a white woman at night.

LOVED (*Her eyes sparkling*). Have you seen her?
AY.

GORDO Not yet—but sometimes—
N.

LOVED But sometimes—go on—do tell me—
AY.

GORDO Sometimes after a day alone in these forests, at sunset, when
N. the heavens seem opening, one half imagines Wisdom is just
behind one, slipping between the trees—I (*hesitates*).

LOVED What an enchanting country. Tell me—
AY.

(Sounds of arrival disturb them. ROBERT HYDE ENTERS. He is like GORDON, but much sturdier. He is very strong and manly, with a more sensual and less spiritual face. A very good fellow.)

NORA. Here's Robert. Robert! I have brought Loveday. This is
Loveday Lewisham. She arrived last week, when you were
out here. She would come so as to see a camp before you
break it up. She wants to see *everything*.
(ROBERT and LOVEDAY shake hands. ROBERT is evidently much impressed.)

ROBERT I'll show her. (*Goes over towards fire, and points to sheep*
enclosures at back.) Do you see those? That's just the
beginning of them. We have a rare good lot of sheep this
year.

LOVED I *am* glad. We need everything good we can get this year.
AY.

ROBERT We need everything we can get every year.

.

LOVED But this year specially. There are so many people in England
AY. who need extra feeding and clothing. Your sheep will be
useful.

ROBERT I hadn't thought of that.

.

GORDO Wool and mutton! Both necessities. Of course we've all
N. thought of that, Robert.

NORA. Loveday is simply obsessed with the idea of the war, and
says we ought not to have any luxuries.

2ND Aye. She's right.
SHEP.

LOVED What is that sheep doing? (*Goes toward the lame sheep by
AY. the fire.*)

ROBERT I dunno. Sick, I expect. Here, Roto. What is that sheep here
for?

ROTO. Leg broke, Boss.

LOVED Oh, isn't it thirsty? Look how its tongue hangs out. Let me
AY. give it some water.

ROBERT (*Smiling.*) It doesn't want water.

.

LOVED Are sheep like rabbits? Don't they need water?
AY.

ROTO. (*Laughing.*) Rabbits!

ROBERT (*Smiling.*) Don't you speak of rabbits to a New Zealander!
. Rabbits are the very devil here! We poison 'em, we shoot
'em, we trap 'em, we set dogs on 'em, we set stoats on to

'em, we imported weasels to catch 'em, we sent to Europe for ferrets to hike 'em out, we breed cats to catch 'em, we wire 'em in, and burn 'em out, and set poisoned corn over their runs, and kill 'em by thousands—but millions of 'em spring up out of the very earth and sometimes threaten to starve out the sheep, they clear the grass out. Rabbits! For the Lord's sake don't speak affectionately of rabbits.

LOVED (*Laughing mischievously.*) Darling little furry things with
AY. nice white tails!

ROBERT (*Groans.*) But you're joking! Come and I'll show you why
. we sheep farmers hate 'em like poison.
(*THEY stroll off together. ROTO takes the empty pail and goes off. NORA and GORDON are left together.*)

GORDO (*Eagerly going, with a possessive air toward NORA.*) Oh, it is
N. wonderful to see you again!

NORA. (*Pertly, teasing him and evidently enjoying it.*) Women are
scarce here, I know, but there's nothing else wonderful about
me.

GORDO For me you are the dream of God which stirs the woodland,
N. you are—(*noting her unresponsive face*). I say, do sit down.
You'll be tired after that ride. Let me take your whip. Take
your gloves off. Those little hands must ache after holding
the reins for three hours.

NORA. Pooh! I like having the reins in my own hands.

GORDO And so you should, they are such clever little hands.
N.

NORA. (*Yawns affectedly.*) Gordon, you're a romantic goose.

GORDO I'm not. Everyone thinks you are wonderful, ask—
N.

NORA. Robert doesn't think I'm at all wonderful.

GORDO Of course he does.

N.

NORA. Then why doesn't he tell me?

GORDO He—he's shy. But besides, though all men may *think* such
N. things about a girl, they only *say* them when they love her.

NORA. (*Quizzically.*) So *you* love me?

GORDO (*Tenderly.*) Is it a hundred or a hundred and one times I have
N. told you so?

NORA. And what have I answered a hundred or a hundred and one
times?

GORDO You have never once said no!

N.

NORA. I didn't ask you what I didn't say, but what I *did* say. And
what did I say?

GORDO (*Persuasively.*) Say something different this time. You can't
N. *always* be cruel, with that sweet face you have.

NORA. Oh, can't I?

GORDO Don't be, then.

N.

NORA. Besides I'm not cruel. You love me. That is very nice for
you. Being in love *is* nice. Isn't it?

GORDO Being in love with you would make the world a heaven if
N. only you were kind!

NORA. I am kind—to myself. Being not in love with you is much
kinder to myself than what you ask. You want *me* to be
happy, don't you?

GORDO Of course! I'd die to make you happy!

N.

NORA. I don't ask *that*. I only ask you not to talk of love.

GORDO How can I not talk of it when I love you?

N.

NORA. (*Turning away.*) Well, if you are willing to die for me, why not stop loving me?

GORDO No man could.

N.

NORA. (*Flattered.*) 'Um. Perhaps. But a *man* could stop talking about it. Talk of something else—anything interesting. What is Robert doing away so long?

GORDO (*Checking his tenderness with an effort, speaking in off-hand tones.*) Shewing Miss Loveday the sheep. I say, she's handsome.

NORA. Oh? *I* don't think so. But you will be soon making love to her I see. I needn't have worried about your worrying me for long.

GORDO Don't say that, Nora. You know you are every beautiful thing to me. I hear your sweet voice every time the bell bird calls. I see your hair in the golden clouds after the sunset; I think of you and the home nest you are making somewhere, particularly when I am out here sleeping out of doors. You know I never shall think there is anyone in the world like you.

NORA. (*Peremptorily.*) Stop! Where *are* Robert and Loveday? Call them, Gordon.

(GORDON *coo-ees*. *An answer is heard.*)

GORDO (*With a little gust of temper.*) You try to prevent us being alone. You grudge me these few minutes. It is cruel.

N.

NORA. Oh. La-la-la! (*Whistles a snatch of tune.*)
(LOVEDAY and ROBERT return, conversing. LOVEDAY comes quickly across to NORA.)

LOVED Oh, Nora, what *lots* of sheep! And the hills, how beautiful
AY. they are. The air is as clear as crystal and the sky seems so big.

GORDO You notice that? Isn't the sky the same size in England, Miss
N. Loveday?

LOVED No! The sky in England seems closer down on us than it is
AY. here. Our sky, even when it is blue, is as though all the smoke from all the chimneys had got on to it and weighed it down a bit.

GORDO Everything is big here; and mostly beautiful. It makes big
N. ideas come into one's head to be so solitary on these wide hills. Big ideas hover but they won't settle down into words, so one doesn't know clearly what they are.

LOVED (*Smiling encouragingly.*) What are they about, the big ideas?
AY.

GORDO Well, of course at present, about the war. The war is so huge
N. one needs to be away from it, like we are here, to see how big it is.

LOVED Yes. I felt that on the voyage out, passing over those miles
AY. and miles of clean, shining blue sea. I'd worked my hardest in a tiny corner till I had broken down, in London you know, but I didn't realise what I had been working at till I was far away on the sea. Then I began to ache and ache to find some way of doing more for it than I had done. (*Whimsically.*) And as I am on the sick list I seem able to do nothing at all.

GORDO But you *have* done something. I've done nothing yet.
N.

LOVED “Your sheep——.”

AY.

GORDO (*Smiling.*) Wool and mutton are useful, I help produce those,
N. but I must do more, Robert and I will both do more when we
see clearly what we ought to do.

LOVED That’s a Briton’s attitude.

AY.

GORDO I’ve thought of joining an Expeditionary Force, but they
N. haven’t called for us yet—and, anyway, I don’t know if that
is the best one can do—to leave all these sheep we are
raising, you know. They *are* needed.
(*The beautiful note of the bell bird is heard calling through
the wood.*)

LOVED (*Clasping her hands.*) What is that? Oh, what is that lovely
AY. note?

ROBERT (*Together.*) That is the bell bird.
and

GORDO

N.

LOVED Is it wild?

AY.

NORA. Of course, it is quite common.

LOVED How clear and sweet! It is the voice of New Zealand herself,
AY. calling to her sisters all over the world, to wake, wake and
sing the triumphal song of the Empire. That song will cross
the waves in a thousand hearts and echo in the very centre of
our lands.

NORA. Don’t be a romantic goose, Loveday. The bell bird is as
common as thrushes are in England.

LOVED You have so much beauty around you, has it become
AY. common to you?

ROBERT Of course not, only we don't say much about it. You at home
. don't pour out poetry over every thrush that sits on a haw-
hedge.

LOVED I would if I could! (*Smiling.*) But I'll try not to make you
AY. think me *too* great a goose. This beautiful country has gone
to my head perhaps. Everything here seems perfect!
(*Noises without of an arrival on horseback, shepherds'
voices, dogs barking, etc.*
ROBERT and GORDON look over their shoulders and exchange
a knowing grin.)

ROBERT I think I hear the voice of *one* in perfection!

.
(ENTER JOHN VARLIE. *He is a florid man, with rather bulging
eyes, a clean shaven face, with a noticeable but small
triangular scar on the right cheek, one eyelid slightly more
closed than the other. He wears American clothes and
speaks with a strong American accent. He is accompanied
by the shepherds and dogs.*)

VARLIE. Waal, boys! Here we are again. I have just delivered your
new shearing gear down at your homestead and they told me
down in the valley I should strike your trail up here, so I
flicked up my grey mare to keep you from feelin' lonesome
without me.

ROBERT (*Amiably.*) Halloo, Varlie. We aren't lonesome to-day.

.
VARLIE. (*Looking from one to the other.*) The ladies! I just can't quit
now though I guess I'm as little wanted as a bug in a
blanket.

ROBERT Not a wet blanket anyway.

.

GORDO You're welcome. We'll show you off. Miss Loveday
N. Lewisham is fresh out from home and wants to see all the
native sights. Miss Loveday, this is Mr. John Varlie, the
universal provider. A regular conjurer who wafts the
appliances of civilisation into our rude wilderness.

VARLIE. Miss Lewisham, I'm proud to make your acquaintance. Say,
cut that Hyde. I'm no conjurer. I'm a plain business man,
and only doing what any other business man could do if he
had the brains.

ROBERT That's it. It takes a Yankee to think of selling the goods we
. want in this part of the British Empire.

LOVED What do you want?
AY.

VARLIE. (*Slapping his leg.*) What I've got here, Miss Lewisham.

NORA. (*A little spitefully.*) I often thought you used your brains to
make them think they wanted to buy what you wanted to
sell.

VARLIE. Aw—come now, Miss Nora. You're real cute, but you don't
think I could monkey with British brains?

NORA. (*Lightly.*) Well, the British brains in *my* neighbourhood are
not fair game for you. (*Looks at ROBERT.*) They don't know
what they ought to want (*looks at GORDON*) or they want
what they can't get.

VARLIE. Well, they all ought to have *this*! (*Produces sample tin
opener from his pocket. The SHEPHERDS look eagerly on.*) Is
there a tin of food stuff around? Sure-ly?

ROTO. Here you are, Boss.
(*Runs to the shelter and returns with one.*)

VARLIE. Now this tin opener won't only save your breath, but it'll let
the recording angel have a holiday. See that? (*Has slit the tin*

round rapidly and easily.) Can you beat that with any tin opener you ever set eyes on?

1ST Noa. That'll be a useful kind—if they all work as easy.
SHEP.

2ND Aye.
SHEP.

GORDO Bully for you.
N.

VARLIE. How many will you take? You chaps ought to have one each. And the ladies! There will be a day when the ladies are alone to get the supper, none of you handy Herculesees around. With this opener, getting the supper is as easy as smiling. Now then! Only sixpence each. Finest American non-rusting steel.

NORA. Fancy wasting your time with such a trifle, Mr. Varlie.

VARLIE. Don't fret. I ain't wastin' my time. I came around your homestead with the big dump of machinery. And I am like the elephant's trunk, calculated to pull up a tree or pick up a pin. (*Laughter.*) I'm picking up more than you think, maybe.

LOVED (*Smiling and counting the people.*) One, two, three, why
AY. there are six of us, if we have one each all round! You don't mean to tell me that you have six tin openers in your pocket?

VARLIE. Yep. 'N I've got a pack horse over there with sixty on it, and sixty dozen in Dunedin, and sixty thousand where they came from! Now, you'll have one, Miss?

LOVED Yes, I will.
AY.

VARLIE. Bully. And you—
(GORDON *takes it half laughing.*)

GORDO All right.

N.

VARLIE. And you—

ROBERT Not I. My jack knife has a claw that's good enough for me.

.

VARLIE. Now, Mr. Hyde, just let me....

(Leads ROBERT aside and tries to persuade him. Meanwhile there is a clatter without as of several horses arriving. A RECRUITING OFFICER and two or three YOUNG MEN, all in khaki ENTER as if just from horseback after a long ride. VARLIE steps aside whispering with 1ST SHEPHERD.)

RE. Hey, lads. They told me I should find a covey of you here.

OFF. Fine! I'm glad we struck your camp. Whew! We're dead thirsty! Have you got any tea?

GORDO Sure. Those kettles are boiling. We'll have tea in a jiffy.

N.

ROBERT Where are you going?

.

RE. Zig-zagging cross country to the outlying stations.

OFF.

(VARLIE aside, whispering with 1ST SHEPHERD. The word "Germany" is overheard.)

1ST *(Indignantly.)* Are you askin' who around here sympathises

SHEP. with Germany?

VARLIE. *(Annoyed.)* No, no, you fool! You ain't got me square! *(Shuts up note-book with a snap and turns away.)*

1ST Are you square?

SHEP.

VARLIE.

(Tipping him.) Here's to prove it. (The SHEPHERD takes the money, but looks rather distrustfully at VARLIE. They separate.)

NORA. *(To RECRUITING OFFICER.)* My! But you look fine! That's the first khaki we've seen round here.

RE. It'll not be the last, Miss. Khaki breeds khaki.
OFF.

ROTO. *(Chuckles. Suddenly, to ROBERT.)* He is the colour of a rabbit, Boss, that's why.

ROBERT Shut up, you fool. This is serious.

.

LOVED *(Laughs.)* Rabbits? *(She looks mischievously at ROBERT.)*
AY.

GORDO Sit down and have tea first, and then tell us all about it.
N.

RE. Thanks. *(To his MEN.)* You may sit down too, lads. We've
OFF. ridden hard. But first water the horses.

(One of his MEN goes out with pails, assisted by ROTO. Splashing and champing sounds are heard. In a few minutes THEY return and sit with the rest.)

ROBERT Are you recruiting?

.

RE. You've hit it, my lad. *(Takes off his hat and wipes his forehead.)*
OFF.

NORA. Let's see your hat. It is smart.

RE. *(Flattered, passes it.)* There, miss.
OFF.

(NORA leans over to LOVEDAY and they examine it together. NORA takes off her own and coquettishly tries it on, catches

ROBERT's eye, he smiles and looks away; catches GORDON's eye, he gazes admiringly at her, she tosses her head and takes the hat off. Mugs of tea are handed round, the men drink thirstily.)

VARLIE. (*Remaining, eagerly listening, leans over to RECRUITING OFFICER.*) Say, stranger, are you getting along well with your job?

RE. (*Keenly.*) And who are you?

OFF.

VARLIE. Waal, I guess it can't be hard for you to lay your finger on the name of my country.

RE. I asked you.

OFF.

VARLIE. I'm an Amurrican.

RE. Passports all right?

OFF.

VARLIE. (*Affecting laziness, drawing them out.*) I should say.

(RECRUITING OFFICER examines them, looks at him keenly, and passes them back.)

ROBERT *He's* all right, Officer! We have had him around the station many a time.

NORA. He's the only man with brains enough to sell us the things we want.

ROBERT He has brains enough to sell us the things we *don't* want.

.

RE. Brains are always suspicious.

OFF.

ROBERT Oh, I say! That's being *too* British! *He's* all right. Some straight men have brains.

.

GORDO And lots of straight men are muddled headed enough to
N. think that wasting peoples time making a lot of truck nobody
wants is good for trade.

RE. Pardon. This tea's good. Have you more, Missy?
OFF.

NORA. As much as *you* want—Officer! Is that what I should call
you?

RE. That'll do for me fine, Missy.
OFF.

NORA. Fill up the kettle, Roto.

RE. Now my men. 'tenshun. (*All three rise.*) We'll have our
OFF. meeting.
(*ROTO returns, and he and the SHEPHERDS crowd eagerly
behind the others listening.*)

LOVED But we seem like friends now, are you going to give us a
AY. formal speech?

RE. When we speak of our King and Country we stand up to it
OFF. like men, Miss.

LOVED Then so do we.
AY.

(*She springs up. All rise and stand round the RECRUITING
OFFICER who is flanked by his own men.*)

RE. God Save the King.
OFF.

ALL. God Save the King.
(*A fleeting sneer is seen on VARLIE'S face, but he shouts
louder than any.*)

RE. (*Oratorically.*) We have lived in New Zealand, some for
OFF. years, some of us all our lives, and we know what New

Zealand means to us. And most of us also know the Old Dart, know her and love her.

SEVERA Hear, hear!

L.

LOVED (*Whispering.*) The Old Dart, what's that?

AY.

ROBERT (*Smiling down on her.*) That's England, Great Britain, our
. pet name for the Old Country.

RE. Now the Old Dart's in trouble, fighting for her life—and, my
OFF. lads, it's not only her life, it's *our* life, too, she's fighting for.
Like a mother fightin' for her young. And, she's not only
fightin for her young, which is us, she is fightin' for the
world! for decency, and truth, for liberty.

ALL. (*Increasingly enthusiastic.*) Hear, hear! That's right. Bravo.

RE. She's fightin' for liberty, fightin' so that promises shall be
OFF. kept between nations as decent men keep 'em between each
other.

(*A murmur of assent.*)

You know if your neighbours were all the time to lie to you
over everything they promised to do, you would never be
able to keep going with them. Like a man, you'd have to up
and show 'em what's what. And that's what the Old Dart is
doing, and it is a big fight. But it is going on in Europe,
which is more than 10,000 miles away from us. You may ask
what has it all to do with *us*?

ROBERT Not us. We know. We *don't* ask what it has to do with us!
and

GORDO

N.

RE. (*Hesitates as if thrown off his track.*) Then you don't need
OFF. my speech. (*Suddenly brightens and smiles appealingly.*)

Don't spoil my speech lads. Pretend to ask so you can hear it. It will make you feel real grand.

ROBERT Fire away then. Hear, hear!

and

GORDO

N.

ROTO. (*Excited.*) That's it, Mister. Give it us.

RE. (*Continues more eloquently.*) Now we are New Zealanders,

OFF. and we live in this free and happy land, you may ask, what has all this trouble in Europe to do with us?

ROBERT Hear! Hear! We do, we do ask!

,

GORDO

N *and*

the

SHEPHE

RDS.

RE. (*Very effectively.*) But I answer you lads, what language do

OFF. we speak? English! What race are we? Britons! Why, lads, the British over there aren't as British as we are; They are English and Scotch and Irish and Welsh—but what are we? All these British strains mixed! Most of us have some Scotch blood and some English blood and some Irish blood mixed in our veins, many of us have been to other parts of Britain and got a touch of Canada, or Australia, or South Africa into us. I say lads we are *more* British than the folks in the Old Dart. We are a fine blend of all the flavours of different Britons, we are the very essence of Britain! We are epitomes of Empire.

ALL. (*Enthusiastic.*) Hurray, that's right. Hear, hear! Go it!

ROTO. (*Particularly enthusiastic.*) We are, we are, hear, hear, Boss!

1ST *(Digging ROTO in the ribs.)* Ho, Ho!

SHEP.

RE. Do I need to tell you it's a righteous war?

OFF.

GORDO We know that!

N.

ROBERT Shut up, let him give us his speech!

.

RE. *(Smiling.)* I wasn't going into that. I don't have to tell our

OFF. lads it's a righteous war. I only asked it like a rhetorical question this time.

ROTO. Go on, Boss, go on. You speak most as fine as a Maori chief.

RE. Now, if Britons are engaged in this war, we are engaged, for

OFF. are we not the Britons of the British? We are. And lads, I will tell you, in the words of our own Prime Minister, Mr. Massey himself, I say to you that "*All that we have and are is staked upon the issue of the war!*"

ALL. *(Tremendous enthusiasm.)* Hear, hear, bravo, hurrah!

(A roar of sound drowns the actual words. VARLIE shouts, but has a slight sneering smile on his lips as he watches the generous enthusiasm of the others.)

RE. Now lads, you know we are free Britons in this country. We

OFF. expect every New Zealander will do his duty because he's glad, aye and proud to do it. You are all only waiting to be told what to do. We have no compulsion. But when you know what we are going to do, you'll all want to join in.

SHEPHE Tell us Mister.

RDS.

RE. We are a small nation. Only about a million souls of us

OFF. altogether, counting women and children. Now that's very

small as nations go. But what are we going to do? We are going to put a larger number of troops in the field than the British had in the great battle of Waterloo!

(ALL *at first incredulous, then wildly enthusiastic.*)

RE. Aye, Aye, lads. Well may you shout. That's what comes of

OFF. being New Zealand Britons. But we are going to do more. We are going to do what the experts tell us is the most possible that any nation *can* do; in three years we are going to have ten per cent. of our total population in the field! That's the maximum, the absolute scientific limit of what any nation *can* put in. And that means from our little country we shall send one hundred thousand men to the field.

ALL. Hurray, hurray!

LOVED (*Glowing.*) How splendid, how splendid you are!

AY.

RE. That's it Missy, that's how New Zealand women take it.

OFF.

ROBERT She's English, she's just visiting from home!

.

RE. From the Old Dart? Our men'll follow you back Missy, all

OFF. of us would like to, only the years have passed over some, and that ties 'em. When the years press on your shoulders you can't carry the knapsack too! And I see some of you chaps are too old.

1ST (*Groans.*) I am, curse the day I was born.

SHEP.

RE. But all of you, every one of you has your part to play. If you

OFF. can't fight you can *save*. That's what the people of New Zealand haven't realised yet. How many of our patriots have reduced their consumption of petrol or of beer by a single gallon because of their patriotism? Yet that is what they must do. That's what we all must do.

Men must fight
And women must save
The path of glory for Britons to pave.

(LOVEDAY *and* GORDON *stand a little apart and are talking.*)

GORDO Ah, this stirs one! I wonder if *this* is what I ought to do?

N.

LOVED (*Smilingly shakes her head.*) I don't know.

AY.

GORDO A man has only one life. That's all he *can* give to his

N. country.

LOVED But the thousands of sheep you raise may be even more
AY. useful! (*mischievously*). It is a question you know—is one
man as much use to his country as his ten thousand sheep?

GORDO Old men can raise sheep.

N.

RE. (*Louder, catching all eyes.*) And now to come to the fighting
OFF. element. I've just said, all of you can do *something*. But
those of you who can fight are wanted now. Have you seen
this paper? (*Takes official set of questions out of his pocket.*)

MEN. (*Shaking their heads.*) No. What is it?

RE. Then I'll read it to you. It is addressed to all men between
OFF. nineteen and forty-five. Which of you are between nineteen
and forty-five?

GORDO (*Looks across at LOVEDAY and says to her alone.*) That's a
N. direct message to me.

(GORDON, ROBERT, ROTO *and the* 2ND SHEPHERD *stand out,*
each saying "I am!")

RE. (*Slapping ROTO on the shoulder.*) How old are you?

OFF.

ROTO. (*Quickly.*) Forty-five, Mister.

RE. Open your mouth.

OFF.

(*ROTO opens and shows browned teeth.*)

RE. (*Laughing.*) Forty-five, with that hair and those teeth!

OFF.

ROTO. (*Protesting.*) I am, I am. My hair gone pale when I was nearly drowned in the Rotorua hot spring.

RE. Get out.

OFF.

ROTO. (*Persistently.*) I'm strong man. I'm young man, see my muscle. Feel my arm.

RE. You are not a Pakeha. You can't fight with the Pakeha.

OFF.

LOVED (*To NORA.*) What is Pakeha? What does he mean?

AY.

NORA. Pakeha are white men, Englishmen.

ROTO. (*Protesting.*) My father was a Queen-Maori.

RE. Was he? That's good.

OFF.

LOVED Whatever is a Queen-Maori?

AY.

RE. In the great war, missy, the Maori war, the Maoris who

OFF. fought on the side of the English, under Queen Victoria, you know, they were called Queen-Maoris.

ROTO. My father fought with Pakeha then, why not me to-day?
Take me. I am strong like the branches of the Kauri pine. I

am hard as my hei-tiki. My father was a Queen-Maori. I will be a Queen-Maori and fight for you. Take me.

RE. You are too old. You are sixty years old if you are a minute.
OFF.

ROTO. No, no.

RE. (*To the 1ST SHEPHERD.*) He is on your station, isn't he? How
OFF. old is he?

1ST Well, we don't know exactly. But it is about six years ago
SHEP. since we had a feast and a good drink because he said it was his fiftieth birthday.

RE. There! Stand aside my man. If you are so strong you must
OFF. do the work the young men leave behind them.
(*ROTO protests, and expresses chagrin but says no more.*)

RE. (*To GORDON not noticing his lameness as he stands with the*
OFF. *others.*) How old are you, sir?

GORDO Twenty-nine.
N.

RE. (*To ROBERT.*) And you, sir?
OFF.

ROBERT Thirty-one.

.

RE. Good! (*To 2ND SHEPHERD.*) And you?
OFF.

2ND Forty-two.
SHEP.

RE. H'm. You look more.
OFF.

2ND I'm forty-two (*glares.*)
SHEP.

RE. (*Feeling his arm and looking at him.*) H'm. Well. Now lads.

OFF. On this paper are the following questions addressed specially to you as you are between nineteen and forty-five. Question A. Have you volunteered for military service beyond New Zealand as a member of an Expeditionary Force in connection with the present war? If so, have you been accepted for service or rejected?

ALL No. No, Boss. No.

THREE.

RE. Well, Question B. If you have *not* volunteered for service, OFF. are you, being a single man without dependants, willing to become a member of an Expeditionary Force? or (2) Are you—? By the way, let's settle that first. Are you all single men?

ALL Yes. Yes. Yes, sir.

THREE.

RE. Then I needn't read the alternative questions. Are you OFF. willing to become members of an Expeditionary Force?

ALL Yes.

THREE.

RE. That's right, lads. Now I'll be honest with you, and tell you OFF. that all the law asks of you is to sign copies of this paper and send them in—you will get them officially in a few days maybe—but that's not what *I'm* here for, to get from you a mere scrap of paper with a promise for the future on it. I'm here to get you yourselves, lads, now. That's better fitted to a Briton than to write his name on a bit of paper, and to go back to his ordinary job! He that puts his hand to the plough and turns back—you know what it says in the Bible. You lads, and I, have got acquainted this afternoon, and I know you're not *that* kind.

ALL No! We are not! We'll come now, right now!

THREE.

ROBERT (*Taking a step forward.*) I'll come at once. That's square.

. (*Looking at LOVEDAY and smiling.*) Can you fit me out in khaki right now, Officer?

RE. The doctor'll have to examine you (*indicating one of the*

OFF. *men with him*) and you'll have to take the oath.

ROBERT Yes, yes. Surely you have an extra uniform handy!

.

RE. (*Smiling.*) It's very irregular, sir. We'll see later, step aside.

OFF.

GORDO Now me.

N.

RE. (*Examines him more carefully. Speaking kindly.*) Step across

OFF. to me, sir.

(*GORDON tries to conceal his limp as much as possible, but of course fails.*)

RE. (*Shaking his head.*) No good, sir. Why, you're lame!

OFF.

GORDO Hardly at all. And I'm strong! I've never been ill. I can ride

N. day and night in the saddle. I'd join the mounted rifles!

RE. Not a bit of good, sir.

OFF.

GORDO (*Unbelieving.*) I'm the right age. I'm strong. I can ride like a

N. cow-boy. I can shoot better than my brother.

ROBERT That's so.

.

RE. Your bit is not at the front.

OFF.

LOVED Oh, officer. Is it impossible? It is such a *trifling* limp.

AY.

(GORDON *looks acutely distressed but smiles bravely and very gratefully at LOVEDAY.*)

RE. Not a bit more good than if *you* was to ask, Missy.

OFF.

GORDO (*Half stammering in his eagerness.*) You must take me,

N. *somehow* or other. You must. I can shoot. I never miss my aim! What is the good of coming here and rousing us all up with your talk of soldiering if you won't take the best shot in the place?

RE. (*Kindly.*) You'll do no fighting, sir.

OFF.

GORDO (*Overcome.*) Curse the tree that staked me! Curse the fools

N. that didn't heal me square!

(*There is an awkward silence. He flings up to NORA, who is a little apart from the rest, his eyes blazing.*)

GORDO Nora, what do you say? Aren't I fit to go?

N.

NORA. (*Calmly.*) Of course not, Gordon. I can't think how you could have expected—

GORDO (*Wildly.*) Now I see why you never loved me! You've teased

N. me often enough. I've made love like a man, but to you, to *you* I was never a man! I see it now. You all think me useless. You don't look on me as a *man*!

(*A tense pause, LOVEDAY and ROBERT look rather awkwardly distressed.*)

NORA. (*Somewhat cowed.*) Don't be silly.

ROBERT I say, old chap, don't take it so hard.

.

GORDO Wouldn't you take it hard if both your country and the
N. woman you love told you plainly you were mere useless
rubbish?

LOVED *(Pitifully.)* Perhaps you will find a still greater thing to do for
AY. your country. It is not *only* fighters she needs.

GORDO *(His lips quivering.)* You are kind. But, oh God!—
N.

(He goes toward shelter away from the OTHERS and aimlessly unfolds the blankets, folds them up again, and re-arranges the pile; opens them out and re-folds them, and so on. Meanwhile, the RECRUITING OFFICER has quietly asked questions of the 2ND SHEPHERD, whose answers are satisfactory.)

LOVEDAY looks from one to the other, then sits brooding, glancing pitifully at GORDON from time to time. While this is going on, the RECRUITING OFFICER takes ROBERT and the 2ND SHEPHERD out, followed by the men with him, leaving NORA, 1ST SHEPHERD, ROTO and VARLIE in a group. LOVEDAY a little apart.)

ROTO. *(Grumbling, to 1ST SHEPHERD.)* You have a black heart, you
Pakeha tutua.

1ST Trying to lie about your age? You are older than I am.
SHEP.

ROTO. Why not lie about your age, too?

1ST What would become of the sheep if I went off? Are the
SHEP. sheep to die on the hills because the Germans are scurvy
dogs? And the best lot of sheep we have had, too, since I've
been on the station!

NORA. When will you black fellows learn not to tell lies? What is
the good of telling lies any way, when you are always found
out?

ROTO. I wouldn't have been if he hadn't wagged his tongue! And to tell a bit of a lie so to give your life, that's no lie.

VARLIE. Ah, Miss Nora, don't try to stamp out necessary lying. The world would be in a queer way if none of us told lies once in a way. I'll wager you this patent button hook you tell lies yourself now and then. Little ones!

NORA. (*Smiling.*) Oh, well—when I say I'm glad to see you, for instance, that's not a lie. It doesn't take you in!

VARLIE. Freeze on to the button hook, Miss Nora. I've won my wager. It is only sixpence.

NORA. (*Tosses it back to him.*) What are you dreaming about, Loveday?

LOVED Before ever I met you all—for months past—I have been
AY. thinking about Gordon's problem. What is one who cannot fight to do for our country?

NORA. Save, as you said yourself.

LOVED It isn't only fighting and saving the nation's needs. It needs
AY. *thinking*. Wouldn't it be splendid to see a man's strength and his brains put into thinking that might save thousands of lives in the time to come.

VARLIE. People who talk about thinking are generally fools. The wise man thinks his hardest how to conceal what he is thinking.

LOVED (*Swiftly and scornfully.*) That's a worldly man, whose
AY. thoughts are grasping. I was dreaming of a man whose thoughts would be *gifts*.

VARLIE. Thoughts are pretty cheap gifts.

LOVED Is there anything we possess that did not grow from a
AY. thought? Isn't the freedom in your country the result of the

thought of the men who framed your Constitution? Isn't all law, all order, all happiness, thought, or the results of it?

VARLIE. Huh! That's too deep for me.

NORA. (*Reproving.*) You are such a dreamer, Loveday. It's so woolly to dream, stop it.

LOVEDAY. My dreams are beginning to clear. If no one had ever thought, we would be savages still. All human beings would be tearing out each other's eyes, always.

VARLIE. Yep. But talking about *my* thoughts is not my job. (*Yawning.*) I must be getting along. When are those fellows going to start?

(Sounds of cheering and laughter and trampling without. ROBERT comes swaggering on in a Khaki uniform with hat jauntily tilted. He is followed by the 2ND SHEPHERD with Badge and Armlet. RECRUITING OFFICER and his MEN follow, grinning. The group round the fire start up. All crowd round ROBERT shouting, admiring and patting him on the back. ROBERT goes up to LOVEDAY and salutes her, she smiles at him cheerily.)

LOVEDAY. Bravo! How fine you look!

AY.

(She looks past him however, to where GORDON is wistfully watching the group, and mastering himself to come forward. She smiles very sweetly and encouragingly at GORDON. The sky slowly takes on sunset tints.)

NORA. (*To ROBERT.*) Give me one of your buttons. I'll wear it.

ROBERT. (*Putting her off, with forced gaiety.*) With the officer looking? Shame on you!

NORA. (*To RECRUITING OFFICER.*) A man who's enlisted is allowed to give away *one* button, isn't he?

RE. *(Smiling.)* One—only one—to the girl he loves.
OFF.

NORA. *(Invitingly.)* Now, Robert, you hear!
 (GORDON overhears this and waits eagerly for ROBERT'S
 answer.)

ROBERT *(Laughs and comically struts.)* Don't shear my feathers off
. me yet!

NORA. *(To VARLIE.)* Men *are* vain.

VARLIE. Take one of *my* buttons! *(Holds out his coat.)*

NORA. *(Eyes flashing.)* When you're in khaki!

GORDO *(Pulling himself together, holds out his hand to ROBERT,*
N. *speaks huskily.)* Good luck, old chap, the best of luck!
 (LOVEDAY looks proudly at GORDON.)

ROBERT *(Claps GORDON'S shoulder with his free hand.)* Keep the
. station going till I come back, sonny.

GORDO I will, Robert.
N.

ROBERT *If* I come back!
.

NORA. *(Excitedly.)* Of course you will. You'll come back with a
V.C., won't he, lads?

ALL. Of course. He's just the make of a hero. Hurrah! Bravo!
 (ALL crowd round him shouting and singing snatches of
 "Rule Britannia, God Save the King," etc.
 The sunset is crimson by now.)

ROBERT Look at the sky! Come, we must be getting back.
.

(ALL follow him, marching, waving branches, etc., singing,
 "See the Conquering hero comes." The rest troop off, but

ROBERT *turns and goes up to LOVEDAY who is lingering and keeps her apart.*)

ROBERT Wait a minute, won't you?

.

LOVED Yes? Of course, what is it?

AY.

ROBERT (*Shyly.*) I say, I—won't you—(*he takes out his jack knife and cuts off a button, offering it to her*) I say, won't you, won't you wear it, just to bring me luck?

LOVED (*Hesitates.*) Oh—I—

AY.

ROBERT Of course I don't mean—to—to bother you in any way. I mean it only in—in friendship! Just to bring me luck. Do! There's nothing in it—nothing silly—like what *they* said.

LOVED (*Smiling, very charmingly.*) Shall I sew it on again for you?

AY.

ROBERT Oh! If you *won't* have it—you may sew it on if I may keep my coat on while you are doing it!

LOVED Very well. Heroes have to be humoured, I suppose. Come along, it's getting late!

AY.

(*THEY follow the others, as she is going off she looks back and sends a compassionate glance towards GORDON.*

The sky rapidly darkens. GORDON stays behind, waits till they are all out of sight, then he throws himself face down on the ground, clenching his hands and moving as though in pain. The bell bird's clear sweet note is heard. He lies in silence then groans aloud.)

GORDO To both my country and the woman I love, I'm not a man.

N. I'm lumber—useless lumber! Nora! Nora!

(*GORDON crouches in despair. The stage is now dusky, a pale moon shows. Softly, without any noise, between the trunks of*

two tall trees appears behind him the upper part of a white figure, with the forehead and head half covered by a floating white veil; the face is tender and grave, the eyes glowing as if inspired. In the shadowy light the figure looks like a vision. GORDON does not recognise that it is LOVEDAY. He slowly, as if mesmerised, rises on to his knees. There is a sweet low call of the bell bird far away. Stillness for a moment. LOVEDAY stands silent between the trees.)

GORDO (*Still half kneeling, speaking in awed tones.*) You are a
N. spirit?

(LOVEDAY is quite still.)

GORDO You are the goddess of the woods come to me in my pain!
N. Tell me, you beautiful, you wonderful—tell me, what have I
to do? Speak to me, speak to me!

(LOVEDAY does not move; in a soft, penetrating voice, she intones, like a chant.)

LOVED AY. The bodies of men that can fight are mown down like the
grass.

The body of one young man, even if he is a prince among
men cannot slay more than a hundred of his enemies.

But by thought a man's brain might conceive of a way to kill
or to save hundreds of thousands.

Now is the time for a Briton to arise who can slay with his
great thought all the enemies of the future.

Now is the time for one to bring forth a noble plan, so that
all the treacherous aggressors shall be for ever disarmed and
the peaceful nations be for ever free from fear of onslaught.

(She draws the veil across her face, takes a step back into the dusk and vanishes.)

GORDO (*Exalted and trembling with eagerness.*) Angel! Goddess!

N. Tell me—how—

(She does not return and makes no sound.)

Slowly the CURTAIN descends.

ACT II.

Three or Four months later than Act I.

The Hyde's Homestead, S. Island, New Zealand. Left back, one end of the low homestead with its broad, creeper-covered verandah abuts on to the garden. A rough piece of road runs across right back of stage. Back cloth painted with luxurious vegetation and vivid blue sky. Mixture of common English fruit trees and Eucalyptus, the lily-palm, masses of crimson ratas in flower.

GORDON HYDE and LOVEDAY DISCOVERED sitting together in garden, down right. GORDON has a sheaf of papers and writing pad on his knee, pen in hand. LOVEDAY is chewing the end of a flower stalk as though thinking.

GORDO (*Laying down papers and looking at LOVEDAY with*
N. *friendship and admiration in his eyes, but not love.*) It is good of you coming over so often to help me. I don't know what I should have done without you. The others try to slay with laughter all my young ideas. I *am* indebted to you!

LOVED No, no! It has been simply splendid for me to see you work
AY. out these great ideas. It has been wonderful to watch the little germ of your conception grow and grow and take practical shape in your wonderful brain!

GORDO Oh, it is not mine. None of all this (*indicating papers on his*
N. *knee*) is mine. All my ideas before that day had been vague and muddled. Now I am only writing down the ideas that vision, that goddess gave me.

LOVED The practical ideas *are* yours.
AY.

GORDO No.

N.

LOVED Yes. Indeed they are, I've watched you shaping them.

AY.

GORDO No. The germ of everything was in that beautiful message

N. she gave me.

LOVED (*Looking at him as though acquiescing tenderly to humour*

AY. *him. He does not see the look.*) Who was it do you think?

GORDO A spirit.

N.

LOVED (*Triumphantly.*) There *are* no spirits you know—no spirits

AY. that talk to living people. The ideas are your own, your very own—

GORDO Perhaps the Maoris are right. This *was* a spirit. It *couldn't*

N. have been imagination! I heard her speak quite clearly. Her wonderful voice was like music, thrilling and deep like the songs of birds in a cool, deep glade.

LOVED But you were overwrought. Imagination plays tricks then.

AY.

GORDO Yes, I was overwrought. That recruiting business had

N. amazingly stirred me. But what she said was so remote from my misery that I *could* not have imagined anything so vital, so full of hope. I felt shamed, anguished. I felt my manhood beaten in the dust, by my country, by the woman I loved.

LOVED (*Murmurs.*) No, no.

AY.

GORDO Do you know what love is? Have you ever loved? If not, you

N. could never understand my shame.

LOVED I have never loved—

AY.

(*His face is averted, she looks at him long and tenderly.*)

until—

GORDO Ah, but you—beautiful and radiant as you are will never

N. know what it is to have love *spurned*—as I have.

LOVED I'm not—so—sure!

AY.

GORDO (*Eagerly.*) Are you not sure that my love is spurned? Do you

N. think Nora, after all, may love me?

LOVED That's—that's not quite what I meant. But—when—when

AY. once Nora sees how the great world honours you for these ideas (*taps papers on his knee*) she will love you, she must. All women will love you and bless you—for you will be the saviour of their sons!

GORDO But Nora is so living—so—*feminine*. I don't think dreamy

N. things like *ideas* appeal to her. Oh, how well I remember her as a girl with her golden hair flying! We three were brought up together, she and Robert and I. She never cared about reading, but always played some real game.

LOVED As she gets older she will see that ideas are real. Perhaps,

AY. and then—

GORDO Wish that for me!

N.

LOVED Are you sure you wish it for yourself?

AY.

GORDO Sure! Wish it for me! There is something wonderful about

N. you. Your wishes would bring me luck.

LOVED I wish you every, every happiness.

AY.

GORDO That's vague. Say, "I wish that Nora may love you and make
N. you happy."

LOVED I wish that if Nora loves you she may make you happy.

AY.

GORDO Ah, *if (suddenly looking at her)*. What's the matter with you?
N. Your voice sounds tired. Are you tired?

LOVED Yes. That's it. I am a little tired.

AY.

GORDO We'll stop the work.

N.

LOVED No, no. See. I'll come here in the shade. (*She moves where*
AY. *he can't see her face.*) Now read over some of what you
have written, and I'll listen critically.

GORDO (*Looks at her for a moment, then reads.*) "The nations shall
N. unite and have a super-parliament to which they shall all
send a small number of representatives. This super-
parliament shall make International laws, but it shall chiefly
exist to prevent any nation flying at another's throat. If
necessary, by force." (*In another tone.*) Flying at another's
throat, doesn't seem formal enough, does it?

LOVED Perhaps not. Mark it. Go on.

AY.

GORDO "In order to prevent any murderously-minded nation flying
N. at another's throat (*in different tone*) as Germany did at
Belgium. *That* example will never be forgotten."

LOVED Never. But go on.

AY.

GORDO “In order to prevent for ever,” I’ll add for ever, shall I?

N.

LOVED Yes.

AY.

GORDO “In order for ever to prevent any murderously-minded nation

N. flying at another’s throat, or stealing any of the rights, or breaking any international law, the super-parliament shall have behind it the whole of the armaments of the world.”

That’s good, isn’t it? *That’s* the point.

LOVED Splendid! That’s where your scheme differs from all the dear

AY. crack-brained pacifists. Have you written out the clauses by which that is secured?

GORDO Yes. (*Shuffles the papers.*) “The super-parliament is to have

N. complete control of all the armies and all the armament factories in the whole world. Any individual or group of individuals violating that monopoly and attempting private manufacture of armaments shall be subject to instant death.”

LOVED Good!

AY.

GORDO You are bloodthirsty!

N.

LOVED I am only cruel to villains to be kind to the virtuous. But I’m

AY. afraid a really sneak-dog nation, like—well, like *some* we could mention, would have made armaments secretly and piled them up.

GORDO No, no, because—(*shuffles the papers.*) Where is it? There is

N. to be a clause preventing any such hanky-panky.

LOVED There is no doubt, that if that is managed properly, however

AY. greedy or treacherous any individual nation might be, it simply wouldn’t *dare* to go to war.

GORDO That's the idea.

N.

LOVED And that is a much more practical idea than that of the
AY. pacifists who talk about *voluntary* limitation of
armaments.

GORDO They idealise human nature.

N.

LOVED Now *your* plan *compels* decent behaviour.

AY.

GORDO *Don't* call it mine. It is all the gift of my fairy genius of the
N. woods.

LOVED (*Smiling as though tenderly humouring him.*) Have you seen
AY. her again—your spirit in the woods?

GORDO No, only that once.

N.

LOVED Well, what you told me of her words then was just the vague
AY. dream of an idea, but look at all these sheets and sheets of
carefully worked out clauses. All these actual, practical,
useful ideas are *yours*!

GORDO They are not. Though I was dreaming and longing vaguely
N. for something of the kind, I'm not big enough actually to
have thought it out.

LOVED You are. You are big enough for anything!

AY.

GORDO Nora doesn't think so.

N.

LOVED (*Scornfully.*) Nora!

AY.

GORDO Why are you so keen on making me think too well of
N. myself?

LOVED Not too well.

AY.

GORDO Why do you trouble that I should even think well of myself
N. at all?

LOVED Because when a man is a man he should respect himself as
AY. one man respects another.

GORDO You are wonderful—women generally try to make a man
N. feel a worm.

LOVED (*Hastily.*) What I like best about this splendid scheme of
AY. *yours* is, that even Germany will *have* to accept it when it is
proposed to her, because she is all the while demanding
“only her own national safety,” and pretending she has no
aggressive desires, so she can’t have the face to refuse to
join in—and yet when she does her militarism will be
choked. Nothing could destroy all militarism more
completely than this!

GORDO Yes. And she would give herself away so utterly if she stood
N. out!

LOVED And if she *did* stand out, she’d—
AY.

(NORA, with a basket of fruit on her arm, enters from road.)

NORA. (*Laughing.*) Halloo, you two? At it again? Settling the affairs of the world in *this* remote spot!

GORDO Why not? Every spot is remote from somewhere else.
N.

NORA. London is not remote from the war, and *if* your ideas aren't boiled gooseberries, they had better get to London.

LOVED Of course they will get to London. All ideas reach London in
AY. the end.

GORDO Robert left me here on trust. I must keep his sheep going, at
N. any rate till I can get a responsible manager. Then I'll go to London.

NORA. London has got too many ideas of its own to listen to an utterly unknown New Zealand sheep farmer.

GORDO (*Sighing.*) It may take time!
N.

NORA. (*Laughing.*) Time! It'll take more than time. You don't know a soul in London.

GORDO I don't, that's flat.
N.

LOVED *I* do.
AY.

NORA. *You* do? Of course you do. You will have to write him introductions. How will you begin? "A young genius, called Gordon Hyde, has ideas to set the Thames on fire. For love of me please give him a match"—or—"Gordon Hyde is my dear friend, and a dear fool, and as sometimes fools rush in where angels fear to tread, please send him in your motor car at once to the Prime Minister."

(BOTH *laugh*, though GORDON *flushes as if somewhat hurt.*)

LOVED You laugh because you don't know how powerful a really
AY. great idea is.

NORA. I don't. Perhaps because I've never met one.

LOVED (*Seeing GORDON looking wistfully at NORA, rises.*) Here,
AY. Gordon, give me those papers. We have done enough for the
present. I'll take them into the house. (*She saunters along
the verandah and enters the house.*)

GORDO Sit down, Nora. You'll be tired after picking all that fruit. I'll
N. carry it over for you when you are rested.

NORA. I can carry it quite well myself. I'm every bit as strong as
you.

GORDO Don't, Nora. Don't always be cruel now.
N.

NORA. I'm not cruel. It would be much crueller to keep you
dangling around, puffed up with hope.

GORDO I'd be happier.
N.

NORA. Only for a bit. It couldn't go on.

GORDO Why not?
N.

NORA. Am I the kind of girl never to marry?

GORDO Nora! You're not—not engaged?
N.

NORA. Not—yet.

GORDO But—when will it be, I wonder!
N.

NORA.

Now, you are rude. Couldn't I be engaged any minute I liked.

GORDO Nora, how you tease me! And yet, I believe, underneath it all
N. you are fond of me—a little.

NORA. Of course, I'm fond of you. We were brought up like brother and sister.

GORDO But now, Nora—oh, bother!
N.

*(There is a hullabaloo outside and ROTO and the 1ST
SHEPHERD run on looking towards road and shouting.)*

ROTO. Hey, mister, here's a sight. Look at that now! The first, the
1ST SH very first that's been along that road. Hoo-o!
EP.

*(There is the sound of a carefully driven car, and a spidery
looking motor car driven by VARLIE draws up at the gate.
VARLIE waves his hat. ALL run forward, LOVEDAY comes out
of the house, the collie dog runs up, and a babble ensues.)*

VARLIE. Yes, siree. I'm the boy to get the hustle on to these roads. I'll
lay my bottom dollar this is the first car that has pulled up at
this Homestead.

SEVERA Yes. It is. It is that. Just fancy!
L.

NORA. I say, *what* an idea! You are a smart man, Mr. Varlie.

VARLIE. Smart! It 'ud tickle a racer to get ahead of me. I'm out to
bring this country up to date. Why, you folk would go on
sleeping here same as if automobiles had never been
invented.

LOVED And I wish they hadn't!
AY.

VARLIE.

You just say that, Miss Loveday, because you are a beautiful English girl—for England's so small it is most over-run with automobiles, that drop off it into the sea—but you wait till you see what this little roundabout can do for these God-forsaken stations.

GORDO (*Grinning amiably.*) Don't you lay it on too thick if you want to sell your car. And I suppose that's what you're after?

VARLIE. Sure! (*Laughing.*) Did you think I was intending to give it to you?

GORDO We might do without it.
N.

VARLIE. Not likely. Not when you had once set eyes on it. The ladies would fair grab at it if you let it slip.

NORA. There is my dad—he'll be mad not to see it. He is away out in the hills, or I'd fetch him along this minute.

VARLIE. Waal, let me show you what this little packet of lightening can do. With this back seat raised she will take four of you into the city in just one-third of the time that your horses would take you on their backs. And you arrive spick and span as a daisy in your glad rags instead of carrying your things to change every time there is a dance or a the-atre.

NORA. (*Clapping her hands.*) Splendid, simply splendid. Wouldn't that be lovely!

LOVED It might.
AY.

GORDO If it didn't jib half way.
N.

VARLIE. No, siree. Not if you drive her right.

NORA. You'll have to learn how, Gordon.

GORDO If *you* have the car I will learn to drive it all right.

N.

NORA. I *must* have it.

GORDO Your dad'll never spend so much just on your running about.

N.

VARLIE. But I've not done yet, by gum! See what business she'll do. See what she will carry. If you don't have that little back seat raised, but have it locked down, this whole back top of her will open out on a hinge, and run behind on runners, stretching her out like a trolley car. See? (*He manipulates the back of car as he speaks.*) Then you put up these rails, bolt 'em together—and look at the freight she'll carry!

NORA, Wonderful! I say, that's neat. Fancy that now! That's a

GORDO difference from my young days.

N and

OTHERS

TOGETH

ER

VARLIE. She won't carry machinery or dead weight like that—but all your ordinary freight—flour, groceries—all you want out from the city—she'll take in your fruit so that you can sell it fresh in town instead of letting it rot on your trees—she—

GORDO Have you sold any around here?

N.

VARLIE. Sold any? Why, there's scarcely a station that isn't ordering one.

NORA. We must, dad *must*!

VARLIE. Ah, Miss Nora. I bet your poppa knows his duty to a peach like you!

GORDO (*Prowls round the car, examining it closely and with interest.*) Where was she made?

VARLIE. That's an Amurrican made sample, but when I have booked enough orders, the firm will set up and make them here.

GORDO It is ingenious.
N.

VARLIE. Any suggestion you like to make, sir, I'll report to my firm. We are out to supply to this country what she requires. It's a fresh, growing country with fresh-growing needs, and the firm that doesn't try to foist off continental models into it, but supplies those needs, will get some business.

GORDO That is so.
N.

VARLIE. Why, the folk around here don't know what it is to spend money. There's a power of unconscious demands right here waiting the supplies. You need to learn how to require luxuries.

GORDO (*Hotly.*) And waste good work making things we are happier without! No! Till this war is settled up, and after it, till everyone is fed and clothed decently, work must be spent on those jobs, not on senseless fripperies which enslave us to make some soulless idiot rich!

VARLIE. (*Strolls towards seat, down left.*) Say! Have you got any lemonade? I'm as dry as a fish. (*Sits.*)
(NORA and LOVEDAY sit near him.)

GORDO Here, Roto, fetch along the drinks! (*ROTO hurries into the house.*)
N.

1ST (*Hovering near car, to GORDON.*) Eh! But it's a fair miracle.
SHEP. Boss!

GORDO (*Leaving the car and coming to outskirts of group, down*
N. *left.*) Like all miracles, it don't seem sure to work.
(ROTO *returns, with tray of drinks and tumblers. GORDON*
helps to hand them round.)

GORDO (*To 1ST SHEPHERD, stretching out with a tumbler towards*
N. *him.*) Here you are.

1ST Thank you, Boss. (*Comes up to outskirts of group and*
SHEP. *stands there sipping his drink.*)

VARLIE. (*Cheerily.*) Waal, and how have you been making time fly
since I was here last?

NORA. Much as usual, only we work harder and—(*laughs*)—
Gordon moons more than ever now he has someone to
encourage him!

VARLIE. Ah, writes poetry, does he, poor chap?

GORDO No. I don't.
N.

NORA. Well, what you do is just as useless.

LOVED It isn't! He is working out ideas of great practical use—
AY. immense—there is nothing more important in the world.

VARLIE. So *that's* how the land lies! (*Twinkling a knowing look at*
LOVEDAY'S *unconscious face.*) And what *is* the great idea, if I
don't intrude?

GORDO It is to make another such war as this impossible.
N.

VARLIE. Oh, ho! That's a *real* smart idea, that is! Are you going to do
it by preaching to the armies, or lovin' 'em like brothers, or
how?

(ROTO *and* 1ST SHEPHERD *guffaw loudly.*)

GORDO I'm no silly mug of a pacifist.

N.

NORA. Their idea—

LOVED *His* idea—

AY.

NORA. Well then, as you like—his idea is to have only one army in the world. Ha, ha, ha. He, he, he! Isn't that practical!

LOVED Nora, you *are* a tease! It's nothing of the sort, Mr. Varlie.

AY. Gordon's idea is to have an international parliament, a super-parliament, and for that to have complete control of an international army, and also—what is very important—complete control of all armament making.

GORDO Then any nation would have all the rest of the world against it directly it tried to do anything aggressive.

LOVED Yes. That's where it will get Germany so splendidly.

AY. Germany *pretends* she goes in for her militarism only for self-preservation. Now this international scheme will secure her self-preservation, but will entirely destroy her militarism and make her aggression impossible!

VARLIE. Donnerwetter! (*Confused, trying to cover his mistake.*)
Sake's alive—

NORA. (*Pertly.*) Are *you* a German?

VARLIE. What do you take me for? I'm Amurrican. But I've travelled in Germany, like most travellers.

NORA. It would be a joke if you were a German, wouldn't it?

VARLIE. (*Cheerfully.*) I'd be taking risks, wouldn't I? But let's hear more of this idea. It's a great idea if it'll kill German militarism! Why (*looking at GORDON*), I'd no idea you were such a top hole genius.

LOVED Now you're laughing, too. None of you seem to think war
AY. *can* be made impossible.

ROTO. That it can't, Missy. Not while men are men.

1ST (*Agreeing.*) That's so, that's so!
SHEP.

LOVED How can *you* think that, Roto? Why, there used to be war in
AY. this very land between you and the English, and now there is
none.

ROTO. That's because the Pakeha are strong. They make laws we
have to obey. If a Maori kill a Pakeha or a Maori now, the
Maori is hung by the law. So Maori and Pakeha live without
killing.

LOVED But that's just it! If the International Parliament was strong
AY. and it made laws, the nations would have to obey and if one
nation went to war and tried to kill another, that nation
would suffer. So the nations would live without war.

1ST (*Shaking his head.*) He, he, he! That's likely! (*Whistles to*
SHEP. *the collie and goes off.*)

VARLIE. Germany would never consent.

GORDO Then she would openly proclaim that her militarism is
N. aggressive and not for self-defence. It would have to be one
of the terms of peace that she did come in.

VARLIE. Waal, that may not be so easy.

LOVED Then all the more need for Gordon's scheme. It is the only
AY. way to destroy militarism.

GORDO Without some such plan the nations will all be burdened
N. beyond endurance, with armament making and the upkeep
of armies.

LOVED AY. And all the lovely face of England will be scarred with factories and works, and her people go grey and weary under roofs instead of singing while they work under the blue sky. And not only in England but everywhere, machines, machines, machines will sap the vitals of men and women and make life a grey and sordid fear!

NORA. Aren't they just *too* absurd for anything, those two! As though it was *their* business to set the world right!

GORDO Whose is it then?
N.

NORA. Nobody's.

GORDO It is the business of everyone to make the world safer and
N. more beautiful—

NORA. (*Putting her fingers in her ears.*) Aren't they hopeless! (*To VARLIE.*) Come along, and I'll show you my bed of English roses. You'll like them.

VARLIE. (*Rises, throws down a nearly burnt cigar and goes with her across stage, standing down right with her to admire a rose bed in bloom.*) I guess you're the best rose among them all.

NORA. (*Smiles as if pleased.*) You have nothing to sell *me*!

VARLIE. No. But I might have something to give.
(*Meanwhile GORDON limps off after smiling at LOVEDAY. She picks up a book and begins to read.*)

NORA. *You* never give anything unless you get its value back!

VARLIE. This time it is a free gift I'm thinking of, but I don't deny I might get its value back! More than its value perhaps.

NORA. Well, I'm sure you haven't got anything I want as a gift.

VARLIE. Ah, you Angel face. Couldn't you take a free gift of a man?

NORA. What man?

VARLIE. Suppose it was myself!

NORA. (*Meditating.*) You are a *man*.

VARLIE. I am that. Would you take me as a free gift?

NORA. But what would I do with you?

VARLIE. Waal—what does a woman do with a man? Sometimes she marries him.

NORA. Oh! Well—but *that* wouldn't be a free gift of a man. You would get me in exchange.

VARLIE. Didn't I say I might get more than its value back for my gift?

(Meanwhile ROTO is sitting on the ground not far from LOVEDAY, finishing VARLIE's cigar, and playing with a carved jade curio. Between the puffs of the cigar, and under his breath, he hums snatches of the following song:

[ROTO. He roa te wa ki Tipirere
He tino mamao,
He roa te wa ki Tipirere,
Ki taku kotiro.
E noho pikatiri,
Hei kona rehitā koea,
He mamao rawa Tipirere
Ka tae ahua.])

NORA. Then that's no bargain for me!

VARLIE. Say, you think it over. I've got a mighty fine business now, and you could help me in it. You could live in the city or run about with me or whatever you liked—and say, Angel face, I think you are just the best ever!

NORA. You're smart—but—

VARLIE. *(Leans over quickly and kisses her.)* Say, Angel face, that's a man's kiss, ain't it?

NORA. Oh! *(Confused, half pleased, half indignant.)* That's not how to treat New Zealand girls! *(She runs into house and slams the door.)*

(VARLIE, satisfied with himself, strolls back across stage and stands looking down at the green jade curio ROTO is cleaning carefully. LOVEDAY continues to read near by.)

VARLIE. Say, Sambo, what's that pretty thing?

ROTO. I'm not a Sambo.

VARLIE. That's right. I beg yours.

ROTO. *(Resentfully.)* My name's Roto, and I thought you knew it, Boss.

VARLIE. I did, then I didn't, and I do now. Waal, Roto, let's get back to the trail. What's that? *(Seats himself so that he can see the curio in ROTO's hands.)*

ROTO. That's a hei-tiki.

VARLIE. A hei-tiki, is it? Does it tick?

ROTO. Silly joke. Hei-tiki is Maori.

VARLIE. What for?

ROTO. For this. *(Shows greenstone charm round his neck.)* Same here.

VARLIE. Let me see.

ROTO. No. No one touch but me. It is tapu.

VARLIE. Tapu? What does that mean?

ROTO. No one may touch but me. This one is tapu, sacred.

VARLIE. I won't hurt it.

ROTO. When tapu put on anything, no one can touch unless tapu is raised.

VARLIE. Waal, and how is the tapu raised?

ROTO. Long ago, only death did—now—oh now, in weak men's time—*money* will raise tapu.

VARLIE. The almighty dollar! And how much money will raise this tapu?

ROTO. Much, very much.

VARLIE. Why?

ROTO. This very rare, very useful hei-tiki.

VARLIE. How so?

ROTO. It has death in it, secret, strong death.
(LOVEDAY looks up from her reading and watches quietly, and with simple curiosity.)

VARLIE. How?

ROTO. Great secret. A very great wise chief found how to get secret poison from karaka kernels.

VARLIE. Karaka?

ROTO. Every New Zealand Pakeha knows karaka seeds, very bad poison. But kills too quick, too ugly, legs all stiff anyhow—all know that karaka poison. But this great chief took part of karaka seed-poison, mixed with magic, and then it kills more slowly in one, two hours after, like as if the man died of himself.

VARLIE. And who do *you* want to kill?

ROTO.

Me? No fellow. All friends. But this hei-tiki useful. It has secret poison, no doctor could tell was poison. That's why tapu would cost much for a pakeha to touch it.

VARLIE. I'd like to have it. How much?

ROTO. Good Maori-stone carved hei-tiki, with secret death. Very much cost.

VARLIE. Twenty shillings?

ROTO. Oh, no, no! Two hundred shillings.

VARLIE. Gosh! Let me see it.

ROTO. No.

VARLIE. Waal, you can't get my bottom dollar for a thing I haven't even seen!

ROTO. *(Holds it carefully in his hands.)* Well, see.
(The audience also can see a green jade carving of very peculiar shape.)

VARLIE. Where is the poison?

ROTO. Quite safe. Inside. If top pressed hard, pushes bottom on one side, and poison drops out.

VARLIE. Is the poison coloured?

ROTO. Three or four drops clear like water. One drop enough. Try! And take the poison yourself!

VARLIE. You old scamp. I guess you are not friends with me. You'd like me to take the poison!

ROTO. *(Cunningly.)* You're not deep friend to our Pakeha, are you?

VARLIE. *(Laughing noisily.)* That's a good one! *(Looks up and sees LOVEDAY.)* Say, Miss Loveday, did you hear that? He don't seem to trust me!

LOVED He has queer intuitions sometimes. But perhaps he is only
AY. afraid of your business superiority.

ROTO. Very cheap, Maori-stone, safe kill, no pakeha doctor could tell.

VARLIE.*(Laughing.)* He's a nice villain!

LOVED He's all right. If he wanted to use it he wouldn't talk about
AY. it.

VARLIE. You're smart. Do you believe in it? Or is he just pulling my leg?

LOVED I believe in it. Gordon knows about a thing like that. I
AY. thought he said it was the last though.

ROTO. This the *very* last. This worth much money.

VARLIE.*(Taking out a pocketful of money.)* Come. I'll have it, to keep you out of mischief. Take twenty shillings?

ROTO. No.

VARLIE. Forty then?

ROTO. No.

VARLIE. Fifty then? *(Lays out the money temptingly.)*

ROTO. *(Looks eagerly at it, then yields.)* Ten more.

VARLIE. Oh, all right! *(Lays down money.)*
(ROTO takes up the money, and hands the green stone to
VARLIE who looks at it [so that audience can see its shape]
then slips it into his pocket.)

VARLIE.*(Laughing reassuringly and sitting a little nearer LOVEDAY.)*
These queer old curios get me every time. I'll test a drop of his precious poison on a mangy old dog I have, and if it is as

he says, I'll wash it out and keep eau de cologne in it. The jade is a pretty shape.

LOVED Yes, it is. And it is quite a good bit of jade, too. It is worth
AY. money. But do be careful with the stuff. I more than half believe what he says.

VARLIE. An old hand like I am at life, don't run no risks with a bit of jade. I've seen too much of the world.

LOVED You have travelled much?
AY.

VARLIE. I should say! I have run around a bit, and got into many a good scrape in my time. Why, any day you are lonesome, Miss Loveday, ask me for the story of my wounds!

LOVED I've been rather lonesome this afternoon. How did you get
AY. that red triangle on your right cheek bone? I have often wondered. It is so regular.

VARLIE. *(Turns his right cheek so that she can see it, points it out and turns again so that audience can see the bright red, definite small triangle on his cheek.)* Ah, now that's one of my best stories. I was a spry young fellow then. *(Looks at her.)* Now, if you were a smart girl you'd say, "That's not long ago then, Mr. Varlie!"

LOVED *(Smiling.)* I'll say it if it is a regulation part of the story. Is
AY. it?

VARLIE. Waal, as you are a high and mighty young English girl, we'll take it as said.
(Sounds of footsteps and panting along road—1ST SHEPHERD hurries on carrying a telegram held out before him.)

1ST Where's Mr. Gordon? Oh, where is he? This telegram's for
SHEP. him.

LOVED He went round the back of the house not long ago.
AY.

1ST Oh, terrible, terrible. That I've to take him this telegram.
SHEP.

LOVED What is it?
AY.

1ST Bad news, terrible bad news. The postman, he told me.
SHEP.

LOVED (*Anxiously.*) But tell us.
AY.

1ST Oh, Missy, how'll ever Mister Gordon take it? Mr. Robert
SHEP. has been killed.

LOVED (*Sinking back in chair.*) Robert killed, oh! poor Gordon!
AY.

VARLIE. Sakes alive, that's a knock out.

1ST That's what I say. It had better been the other way about.
SHEP.

LOVED (*Swiftly, in anger.*) How can you say that?
AY.

NORA. (*Running out of house.*) What is the fuss?

1ST (*A little important as being the bearer of sad news.*) Ah,
SHEP. Missy, it's sad tidings there is in this telegram. Mr. Robert's
killed.

NORA. (*Screams and staggers. LOVEDAY springs up and goes to her.*) Robert, Robert! Killed. How do you know? It must be
lies. How do you know?

1ST Postman told me. This is a Government telegram, telling it
SHEP. to ye, official.

GORDO (*Hurries round the house and comes centre forward.*)
N. Whatever is the matter?

(ROTO comes in and learning news from VARLIE, shows signs of real grief.

ALL hesitate to tell GORDON. 1ST SHEPHERD holds out telegram.)

1ST It's, it's bad news, Mister Gordon.

SHEP.

GORDO The telegram is official—it's—is Robert wounded? *(Tears open the telegram.)*

GORDO Killed! *(Lets telegram fall, and staggers forward to chair, all are silent.)*

NORA. *(Crying softly.)* Oh Robert, Robert, Robert!

(LOVEDAY tries to soothe her and is sad also. ROTO sniffs. The collie dog comes up to the group, looking from one to the other, then goes to GORDON and rubs against him licking his hand. GORDON pats him.)

GORDO Good old chap. Yes, he'll never come back. Your master is
N. dead—died a hero's death.

VARLIE. *(Comes up and shakes GORDON's hand.)* Accept my
condolences.

GORDO Thanks—thanks, you're kind. *(Pays little attention to him, goes over to NORA, who is still weeping.)* Nora, dear. *(He kneels beside her.)* How sweet of you to care so much—he, he'd be proud if he knew.

NORA. *(Fiercely.)* He wouldn't! He never cared for me. And I loved him—and I hate you. Go away!

(She pushes him roughly from her so that, on his knees, still, he scarcely keeps his balance. She turns and weeps fiercely in LOVEDAY's arms. LOVEDAY, soothing her, really watches and feels for GORDON. As he staggers blindly to his feet, she looks with infinite tenderness and pity towards him and stretches out a hand to steady him. He takes it, and clasps it for a moment.)

ROTO. (*Wailing.*) What'll happen? What'll happen now Mister Robert won't come back?

1ST Eh, eh, dear, dear.

SHEP.

GORDO He won't come back! (*He looks up suddenly, and seems to*
N. *gather strength.*) He won't come back! He has done *his* job for the Empire! That frees me! Now I'll do mine! I've nothing to keep me here.

1ST Why! the sheep do, Boss.

SHEP.

GORDO Robert charged me to keep the station going for him till he
N. came back. Now he'll never come back; I'm done with the station! Other men must raise the sheep.

LOVED (*Her eyes sparkling.*) You'll go to London?

AY.

GORDO Yes. We have often said I'd have to go to London some day
N. to get *my* job put through.

VARLIE. (*Half aside.*) The man's mad! He doesn't propose seriously to bring forward that devilish scheme of his. (*Aloud.*) What will you do? Have you the dollars? It'll take a good deal of money!

GORDO No. All I have is the homestead, and the sheep. But I'll sell
N. them.

VARLIE. It's the worst time to sell just now.

GORDO I'll lose something of course, but the homestead and all is
N. really worth quite ten thousand pounds altogether.

VARLIE. Snakes! It's not worth nearly half that.

1ST Yes it is, Mister. It's a good station. None better hereabouts.

SHEP.

VARLIE. Is it freehold?

GORDO Yes. And unencumbered.

N.

VARLIE. Is it all yours?

GORDO Yes—*now* it is. Robert and I shared it. He left his will with
N. me—he said his share was all for me, as he hadn't got a girl.

(NORA *is seen to shudder as though hurt.*)

VARLIE. Then you can sell at once.

GORDO I shall.

N.

1ST Don't 'e, Mister Gordon, don't 'e. You'll best wait. Land's
SHEP. not sellin' just now. Wait a bit.

GORDO But my work won't wait! I shan't.

N.

LOVED Splendid! Go.

AY.

GORDO You say so? You back me?

N.

LOVED Yes. Yes.

AY.

GORDO Well, I have one on my side.

N.

VARLIE. It's a fool business.

GORDO I must sell at once. Perhaps neighbour Lee might like to join
N. this station on to his.

NORA. (*Looking up fiercely.*) My dad? I won't let him. I won't!

VARLIE. You'll not get a purchaser at present.

ROTO. That's true, Boss. No one is buying land just now.

GORDO (*Turning away.*) Well, I must sell for else I have no money to
N. go to Europe with and I *will* go. It will be a very expensive
job. Propaganda costs. I must put my scheme before the
Prime Minister of England, and it's no good to write to him.
I must see him, I must talk to him.

VARLIE. Has he a good opinion of you?

GORDO He doesn't know me yet.
N.

NORA. (*Scolding.*) How do you think that you, an absolutely
unknown Colonial with a hair-brained scheme, are going to
get at him?

GORDO I'll manage it somehow.
N.

VARLIE. London is not like Dunedin, I opine. Do you know anyone in
London who knows the Prime Minister?

GORDO No. But I'll get to.
N.

NORA. Do you know a single living soul in London?

GORDO No. But I will when I get there.
N.

LOVED He will. *I'll* see to that!
AY.

NORA. (*Spitefully.*) Oh! Do *you* know people who know the Prime
Minister of England?

LOVED (*Quietly.*) I do.
AY.

NORA. (*Taken aback.*) Oh! Who?

LOVED The Duchess of Rainshire.

AY.

VARLIE. (*Very alert, evidently taking note of the name.*) Does she know the Prime Minister intimately?

LOVED Yes. He often comes to see her.

AY.

GORDO (*Triumphfully.*) Splendid! You never told me that, Loveday, when you said I should have to go and see him somehow.

LOVED (*Smiling.*) I had it up my sleeve though. There was no need to speak of it so long as you were not going. Now (*sadly*) you can think only of this work. I'll be proud to help in it. It is worth doing.

GORDO With Robert's example before me—I'll do it, or die.

N.

LOVED You'll do it.

AY.

GORDO But it may take a long time, and I must have money, plenty of money too. I must sell the station at once.

VARLIE. (*Drawling.*) I've put my thinking cap on. A business connection of my firm is looking out for freehold in this country. If this is freehold, I reckon I'd be safe to get my money back from him if I bought it myself.

GORDO You!

N.

VARLIE. Yaas. I've got plenty of free cash when it's wanted, you know. Business hasn't been bad lately, and—waal. I'll lay down for this freehold of yours.

GORDO Good. That'll save ever so much time I might waste in looking for a buyer.

VARLIE. Let's strike then.

GORDO It is worth ten thousand pounds.

N.

VARLIE. Shucks!

GORDO But I'll take less.

N.

VARLIE. Waal?

GORDO Say seven thousand—for money down.

N.

VARLIE. (*Laughing derisively.*) What do you take me for?

GORDO It is really worth that, why the sheep alone—

N.

VARLIE. Sell your sheep separately then. I ain't buying sheep, I'm buying land.

1ST But you can't do nothin' with this land without sheep, Boss.
SHEP.

ROTO. It's worth more than seven thousand pounds, that's a bargain price, Boss.

VARLIE. Sell elsewhere then.

ROTO. Do, Mister Gordon. Next month a Pakeha I know is coming to the city. He thinkin' of a station like this. I fetch him along, Mister Gordon.

GORDO Next *month*! I want to be half way to England next month.

N.

VARLIE. (*Lighting a cigar.*) I'll give you four thousand five hundred for it—

GORDO That's too little to discuss.

N.

1ST That's robbery, Boss, don't take it. After the war it'll fetch

SHEP. three times that. After the war—

GORDO After the war will be too late for me. The international

N. super-parliament must be considered in the terms of peace.

1ST (*Groans.*) Them ideas! You'd let the sheep rot for ideas!

SHEP.

VARLIE. I'll give you four thousand five hundred for it, down *to-day*.

GORDO To-day!

N.

VARLIE. Right now. We'll ride into the city and get a notary to fix it
up all square.

GORDO That's better than waiting for an uncertain buyer—but it's

N. very little—

VARLIE. But it's here, *to-day*.

GORDO To-day. Well, I'll take it!

N.

VARLIE. Done. A deal. Shake.

(ROTO and the SHEPHERD mutter, and shake their heads.)

NORA. You're a perfect *fool*, Gordon! You throw away more than
half your fortune so as to be able to rush off to England with
a crack-brained scheme! Why not write to the papers
instead?

GORDO (*Looks helpless, says appealingly.*) Oh, Nora!

N.

VARLIE. A lot of energy is let off safely in gas to the papers. Hyde is
bottlin' his energy up it seems. That makes him dangerous,

eh?

GORDO (*To Loveday.*) You'll give me a letter of introduction?

N.

LOVED (*Smiling sweetly.*) No. I won't.

AY.

VARLIE. Gee. Even *she* thinks you are going off the rails.

GORDO Loveday, you *said* you would give me a letter of
N. introduction!

LOVED How many introductory letters do you suppose the Duchess
AY. of Rainshire gets? A *letter* would do you very little good.

GORDO (*Crestfallen.*) Oh, Loveday, what do you mean?

N.

LOVED Why! (*Taking a step towards him, radiant, in the centre of*
AY. *stage.*) I'm not going to trust to letters, which people can put
in the waste-paper basket!

GORDO But, what do you mean, Loveday?

N.

LOVED *I'll come with you myself!* I'll wait on their doorsteps (I
AY. know lots of people in London), I'll waylay them at parties,
and seize the very *best* opportunities for getting the right
people to know you.

GORDO You will? You are a brick! How splendid!

N.

VARLIE. (*Somewhat disturbed, aside.*) Ach! The English are mad
enough for anything. Gott sei dank I know of this! (*Aloud.*)
What about Mrs. Grundy?

NORA. Yes. A pretty pair you will look. What will people say?

LOVED When the whole world's future is at stake, do you think I
AY. care what people say?

VARLIE. Who was it said the English are all mad? He was right.

GORDO It is too much, Loveday!

N.

NORA. You are English. You will make me agree with Mr. Varlie's opinion of your country's sanity.

LOVED
AY. British women are free from the need to care what foolish people think! (*Turning to GORDON.*) We will go to London, Gordon, and there I'll work for you and your great idea, for all I'm worth!

(*GORDON takes a step towards her, his face shining with enthusiasm.*)

CURTAIN.

Act III.

About a Couple of months later than Act II.

The Duchess of Rainshire's drawing-room, London. The fore-part of the stage represents an alcove of the big drawing-room; the back of the stage opens out so as to suggest a large room beyond. Heavy curtains hang on either side of back of alcove. Left second entrance, a door leading direct from alcove to outer hall. Left front, up against wall and projecting into room, a grand piano, closed. Right front, a large Chesterfield placed at convenient angle. One or two small chairs, big pictures, a palm or two, etc., as in a first class house.

THE DUCHESS OF RAINSHIRE, LOVEDAY and GORDON DISCOVERED in the foreground. Back of stage occasional guests pass to and fro in the big drawing-room, and faint sounds of music in the distance are heard.

THE DUCHESS is a middle-aged, smart woman of the world, with a commanding manner and quick way of speaking, but kindly.

GORDO (*Standing, speaking earnestly declaiming as though*
N. *concluding a long argument.*) I fear I have bored you, there is so much to say, but perhaps the chief point is that there shall not only be international law, but adequate force behind that law to enforce it.

DUCHES (*Stifling a yawn.*) Well, Mr. Hyde, I'm sure I wish you the
S. success you deserve, and not what I fear you are likely to get. London simply swarms with panaceas and their parents.

LOVED (*Appealing.*) But they haven't all got you to help them!
AY.

DUCHES Oh yes, most of them have! But mercifully the schemes
s. counteract each other on the whole, or where should *I* be?

LOVED You must not allow *anything* to counteract this.
AY.

DUCHES (*To MR. HYDE.*) Well, young man, remember! It's neither for
s. yourself nor for your ideas I'm launching you on the
defenceless man at the helm, but simply because Loveday
used to have fascinating freckles on her nose when she was
six years old.

GORDO I know I owe her an awful lot. And you too. I'm ever so
N. grateful, I can't say how grateful. Posterity will—

DUCHES (*Interrupting.*) You are going to say that I'll go down to
s. history as the patron of genius, of course—I'm glad to hear
it. It may help to counteract the *other* way I shall go down to
history. No one who has had two successive husbands, both
Dukes, could fail to find posterity as critical as the present
generation is spiteful.

(GORDON *looks bewildered.*)

LOVED Don't believe her, Gordon. Everybody's awfully fond of her.
AY.

DUCHES Go and think that over somewhere by yourself, young man. I
s. haven't seen Loveday since her escapade into Greater
Britain and I want to hear from her how this little island
looks in true prospective.

(GORDON *bows and goes toward back of stage and mingles
with other quests, strolling out of sight. Meanwhile a guest
or two stroll partly round the alcove, but seeing the DUCHESS
talking, retire.*)

DUCHES (*Taking LOVEDAY's arm and pushing her down on to sofa,
s. sits beside her.*) Now, Miss, your confessions.

LOVED He is really wonderful.

AY.

DUCHES Though New Zealand is British my experience of home
s. Britons tells me it is not peopled by geniuses. He is
exceptional. Naturally.

LOVED Not at all naturally.

AY.

DUCHES Hoity-toity.—I'm not old enough to say that properly, but it
s. is so effective, I'm beginning young, so as to get enough
practice before my public use of it. So—hoity-toity!
(LOVEDAY *smiles, says nothing.*)

DUCHES What's wrong, don't I say it properly? It ought to elicit some
s. retort from you which should reveal your secret more
completely than ever.

LOVED I haven't got a secret.

AY.

DUCHES Hoity-toity!—I think I did it rather better that time—
s.

LOVED (*Earnestly.*) I *haven't* a secret really!

AY.

DUCHES I must have done it better: you retorted, telling me that you
s. have a secret.

LOVED (*Laughing.*) I haven't, really and truly I haven't.

AY.

DUCHES Hoit—no. I'll vary it. Fiddlesticks! Who is it?

s.

LOVED *Who* is what?

AY.

DUCHES Whom are you in love with?

S.

LOVED Nobody.

AY.

DUCHES Is he in love with you?

S.

LOVED Who? Nobody? Yes. Nobody is in love with me.

AY.

DUCHES He. (*Points with her fan through opening of alcove.*) Your

S. New Zealand Genius.

LOVED (*A shade despondently, but unconscious of it.*) No, he is not.

AY.

DUCHES (*Pouncing.*) Ha! that's it, is it?

S.

LOVED That's what? Oh, dear! Why is it I always talk such bad

AY. English when I am with you?

DUCHES Tush. Tell me about him!

S.

LOVED (*Brightening.*) Oh, how nice of you. I did so want you to

AY. take an interest in his ideas. They are so *wonderful*. They will make—

DUCHES I don't care one Jellicoe submarine about his ideas. Tell me

S. about himself.

LOVED He is a little lame, poor boy—

AY.

DUCHES So I *have* observed.

S.

LOVED But it isn't fundamental. He got a stake through his thigh
AY. when he was a lad and it healed badly. It must have been
dreadful for him.

DUCHES Are you going to marry him?
S.

LOVED Oh, how *can* you say such things? It has never entered his
AY. head!

DUCHES Hoity-toity.
S.

LOVED Oh, it hasn't!
AY.

DUCHES Well, here is a personable young man for whom you feel
S. pity, and you are twenty-seven to his thirty. I only ask, are
you going to marry him?

LOVED (*Rising indignantly.*) How *can* you say such things. I never
AY. thought of it! Why he—he loves someone else!

DUCHES Oh, *that's* the trouble, is it? Where is she?
S.

LOVED In New Zealand.
AY.

DUCHES (*Patting LOVEDAY's hand.*) Then that's all right, my dear.
S. You can have him if you want.

LOVED But I don't want, that way.—Oh, I don't want any way! Oh,
AY. why *do* you have such dreadful conversations?

DUCHES That's it. Quarrel with your benefactor! Are you going to
S. flounce out of the house *before* the Prime Minister comes?

LOVED I can't now—but I'm not going to take anything back
AY. because you promised to help us.

DUCHES (*Laughing delightedly and pulling LOVEDAY down again*
S. *beside her.*) Oh, so it is us?

LOVED Only for this piece of work, till his idea is launched, of
AY. course. What do you suppose I came across from New
Zealand for?

DUCHES (*Chuckling.*) I wondered.
S.

LOVED Don't you care a bit for a big idea that will help the world?
AY. Can't you imagine a woman gladly crossing the world to
have even a small share in helping it forward?

DUCHES I could imagine it; but I have never yet *observed* it.
S.

LOVED Well, you can now. Look at me.
AY.

DUCHES I do, my child, and I see a young woman in love.
S.

LOVED (*Shaking herself.*) Ooh!
AY.

DUCHES Never mind, my dear. He is a personable young man
S. enough. There are no available Dukes, Earls or Marquises I
can recommend at present and I believe in people marrying
for love. I have seen too much of the other thing. So what
can I do for you?

LOVED You know quite well. I only asked you, begged you, to make
AY. the Prime Minister listen to him.

DUCHES Oh, the poor man! When he comes here for an hour it is for
S. relaxation and quiet. He looks to me to *protect* him from
Cranks, not to stuff them down his throat.

LOVED (*Emphatically.*) Gordon is *not* a crank.

AY.

DUCHES All cranks have emphatic relatives who testify ardently to
S. their sanity.

LOVED I'm *not* his relative.

AY.

DUCHES Hoity-toity.

S.

LOVED (*Smiling.*) That doesn't react with me any longer. (*Coaxing.*)

AY. Come now, be an *angel* and introduce Gordon to the Prime
Minister. Don't say anything about your suspicions that he is
a crank. Just say he is a nice young man from New Zealand.

DUCHES And what am I to say about you? Or are you dying to be
S. sacrificed on the altar of friendship and have nothing said
about you?

LOVED Oh, yes.

AY.

DUCHES You don't insist on an introduction too?

S.

LOVED No. I ask only one introduction. Promise *that*.

AY.

DUCHES Very well.

S.

LOVED You darling!

AY.

DUCHES But I will use the introduction for you, not the man. The
S. Prime Minister likes young girls if they are at all good
looking, and I think one may call you that.

LOVED Oh, you mustn't! I *won't* be introduced.

AY.

DUCHES What! You refuse to be introduced to the Prime Minister?

S.

LOVED (*Punching a cushion.*) I do. I do absolutely. That one

AY. introduction is for Gordon. You *promised* one; and Gordon is to have it.

(THE REV. DR. VARLIE, *separating himself from the guests, has strolled into the alcove.*)

DUCHES Well, I suppose it must be.

S.

LOVED You are a *dear*.

AY.

DUCHES But for your purpose, it is not the Prime Minister you want

S. first of all. There is another Cabinet Minister whose word in the Prime Minister's ear would be priceless.

LOVED Oh! Then *please* introduce Gordon to him first!

AY.

DUCHES He's very amiable.

S.

LOVED Splendid. Is he here to-night?

AY.

DUCHES Yes. Go and fetch your phenomenon. If you two are to be

S. found here when wanted. I'll either send for you or stroll this way with him if I can.

LOVED Thanks *awfully*! (*Goes through curtains, to drawing-room beyond.*)

AY.

(THE REV. DR. VARLIE *advances. He has a considerable beard, and wears clerical garb. He politely presents himself to the Duchess. She greets him without enthusiasm.*)

DUCHES Oh, Dr. Chapman, I'm glad you found time to come for a
s. little relaxation.

VARLIE. Oh, dear lady. I take no relaxation in these sad times. But I
wanted a word with you before your next Committee for the
relief of the homeless Serbians. As you know, the American
people have been stirred to the depths, and out of the fulness
of their hearts they have sent *me* to join my ministrations
with yours. As you well know, these weeks past I have put
my back into it.

DUCHES Very good of you I'm sure. We can't have too much help.
s. *Practical* help.

VARLIE. At the last Committee Meeting I opined that a cheque would
not be out of place in your hands, Duchess.

DUCHES Never.
s.

VARLIE. (*Taking out his pocket book.*) Waal, my flock answered my
prayers, and sent this to me for you. If you could sign the
receipt yourself, Duchess, it would be like placing seed in
fertile ground. I know your secretary does such routine work
for you, Duchess, and that's why I took this chance of
handing it to you myself.

DUCHES Of course I'll sign the receipt if you like. Is that all?
s.

VARLIE. Waal, the other business will do when we meet at the next
Committee.

DUCHES (*Moving off, back of stage.*) Then come along with me, and
s. I'll find you an interesting girl or two to entertain you. You
just missed one as you came in.

VARLIE. So I divined from her earnestness. A lovely type.
(*They go out together. In a moment LOVEDAY and GORDON
return.*)

LOVED So we are to sit *here* till she comes or sends for you.

AY.

GORDO (*Gratefully.*) I say. You do work miracles.

N.

LOVED It is the Duchess who will do that. Isn't she a dear?

AY.

GORDO She terrifies me rather.

N.

LOVED For moments, just at times, she terrifies me. But all the safe

AY. times in between I know she is a dear.

GORDO I say, I'm nervous you know.

N.

LOVED Oh, *don't* be! You will only have a few minutes this time:

AY. just to make a good impression. If you do that then the
Minister may give you a serious interview later.

GORDO I'm wretchedly nervous. Is he, is he *short* with people?

N.

LOVED He likes people to be short with him! He is dreadfully bored

AY. by long-winded cranks of course.

GORDO I say, what do you think? (*Pulls out some papers from his*

N. *pocket.*) I thought of wording Clause 29 of the suggested
constitution as follows: "The Super-Parliament is to have the
power of prohibiting the manufacture of *anything* which in
its opinion constitutes a menace to the Peace of the world:
with power to inflict the death penalty on all concerned in
any infringement of its prohibition in any country."

LOVED Yes. I think that is good. Coupled with the other clauses that

AY. makes it safer.

GORDO I hope the Prime Minister will see that. I must learn this
N. clause off by heart now. Teach it to me, will you?

LOVED You don't know the other clauses off by heart, *do* you?
AY.

GORDO Yes, of course I learnt them. I couldn't *read* them to the
N. Prime Minister, could I? And I'm so nervous, I'd muddle
them up unless I just learn them off.

LOVED (*Horried.*) You don't intend to *say off* all the thirty-three
AY. clauses of the suggested constitution to the Prime Minister at
this first meeting, do you?

GORDO (*Simply surprised.*) Why, yes! I'm to tell him the ideas,
N. aren't I?

LOVED Good heavens! not in a block like that though. After you
AY. have made an impression on him you must give him these
all typed out so that his secretaries and colleagues and
everybody can make marginal notes on them and hash them
up.

GORDO If I'm not to say the clauses I have learnt, what on earth *am* I
N. to say?

LOVED Say you have an idea worth his serious attention—say—oh
AY. —whatever he makes you *feel* will reach his attention!

GORDO Good heavens. What a gamble!
N.

LOVED Not a bit. The inspiration will come.
AY.

GORDO *You* have been my inspiration for so much of this.
N.

LOVED No, no. I have only suggested a word here and there.
AY.

GORDO I owe you so much. How strange it is I should have met you
N. the same day that the vision came to me. Next to my vision-
spirit, you are the source of all the ideas worth anything in it.

LOVED Nonsense. Absolute nonsense. I simply had nothing concrete
AY. in my mind at first! It is you, you, *you* who have put all the
ideas into practical, living, useful shape.

GORDO But *I* had no concrete ideas at first!
N.

LOVED Well, *you* evolved them out of your inner consciousness.
AY.

GORDO (*Obstinately.*) The vision, and you, gave me the ideas to
N. work out.

LOVED (*Almost irritably.*) It's sheer *nonsense*, that old vision! The
AY. thoughts were yours, yours, *yours*! She only mumbled a
little vague *tosh*!

GORDO (*Astonished.*) Loveday!
N.

LOVED Well, I'm tired of seeing you being so humble, and failing to
AY. realise how splendid you are, and how the credit of it is all
your own.

GORDO Loveday.—You don't really think that?
N.

LOVED I do.
AY.

GORDO (*Whimsically.*) I'm so accustomed to women thinking poorly
N. of me—Nora—

LOVED (*After a pause.*) Does she—does she still *hurt* you, Gordon?
AY.

GORDO No I have waked from my foolish dream of love for her.

N. She, she was too cruel—and besides—she, you know, you heard—she loved Robert.

LOVED (*Joy showing in her face, which she tries to conceal.*) Then

AY. you feel free.

GORDO Yes. Thank God I'm free from love of any earthly woman.

N.

(LOVEDAY's *face falls.*)

GORDO *You* make most women look small, and then—then—

N. anyway, I'm not the type of man such a woman as I could love now, would look at. Thank God, no mortal woman can rack my heart. My vision Queen has my heart and my dreams.

(LOVEDAY *looks bright—then a little mischievous.* VARLIE *returns, strolling round the room, unnoticed by them. He starts somewhat at seeing them talking together so deeply and nods as if recognising something and saying “ha ha” to himself. He studies the angle of the room and places himself back of the piano, turning towards the wall and pretending to examine a picture. Meanwhile LOVEDAY and GORDON continue, unaware, to talk.*)

LOVED Spirits *don't* appear. She must have been a real woman.

AY.

GORDO Impossible.

N.

LOVED But a spirit is *more* impossible! (*triumphantly*). So you see,

AY. every single bit of credit for it is yours.

GORDO Yours.

N.

(*Both laughing say together “yours.”*)

(*From back of stage, enter CABINET MINISTER with the*

DUCHESS. THE MINISTER *is old, benign and white haired, with*

a long white beard. A plain clothes detective [SMITHERS] in evening dress follows him at a little distance and hovers near the curtains at the back.)

MINIST Ah! I remembered that this alcove is generally nice and
ER. quiet. You are a good hostess, my dear.

(THE DUCHESS throws a comical look at the back of the sofa where GORDON and LOVEDAY are sitting.)

DUCHES I'm glad you think so! It isn't easy to satisfy different people
S. at the same time.

MINIST All I ask is a quiet cup of coffee with you, my dear. Can we
ER. have some coffee here, by the way?

DUCHES Of course. *(Slips quickly to wall and rings.)* It will be here
S. directly.

MINIST And your coffee is good. Ah, it reminds me of Paris in the
ER. late seventies—when I was a young man. But you didn't know Paris in the late seventies I expect? No, no, of course not.

(MAID in smart uniform, waistcoat, brass buttons, enters from entrance right, going quickly up to the DUCHESS, who whispers "coffee at once, here." MAID goes out.)

MINIST Paris in the seventies was an adventure.
ER.

DUCHES Any city is an adventure to the right man.
S.

(MAID enters with coffee, MINISTER helps himself to sugar and cream, stands centre of stage holding it in his hand.)

MINIST That's true. You are a witty woman, my dear. And that's a
ER. thing not often come by now-a-days.

DUCHES Modern women are all clever, and cleverness kills wit as a
S. magnifying glass kills a complexion.

MINIST Good, good.

ER.

(LOVEDAY and GORDON, observing their nearness, rise and stand a little way off. The DUCHESS signals imperiously to LOVEDAY, but she makes a determined grimace and slips round the left side of the sofa. As she leaves GORDON she whispers "The great moment is coming—Good Luck." GORDON stands hesitating. The DUCHESS signs to him to come forward.)

DUCHES Ah, *here* is the young man of whom I spoke to you. May I
S. introduce Mr. Hyde? You said you could endure a chat with him. He wants your influence with the Prime Minister you know. I tell him *you* are even more important.

MINIST Flatterer!

ER.

(LOVEDAY behind the group waves her hand joyously. HYDE looks relieved and very pleased.)

DUCHES The power behind the throne, Mr. Hyde.

S.

MINIST *(Kindly.)* Ah, how do you do, Mr. Hyde.

ER.

(Shakes hands after carefully turning and laying down his coffee cup on the corner of the piano behind him, placing the cup so that it is on the audience side of the piano. VARLIE, who is still standing with his back to the group, looking at the picture above the piano, notes this quickly and keenly. He is seen by the audience to be listening intently.)

MINIST How do you do. You come from Australia I believe?

ER.

GORDO New Zealand, Sir.

N.

MINIST New Zealand, yes, yes. A thousand miles by sea from the
ER. nearest port in Australia.

GORDO Yes, Sir.

N.

MINIST I remember that because I was there myself when I was a
ER. young man and very much it surprised me to be sure. I had
always pictured New Zealand as being to Australia like
England to the Continent. Yes, yes. A thousand miles away.
Just think what a difference it would make, if *England* were
a thousand miles from France at this present moment.

GORDO Yes indeed, Sir.

N.

MINIST So it is very fine of you young New Zealanders to join in
ER. with us all the way you do. Very fine.

(LOVEDAY *crosses to right of stage and looks curiously at*
VARLIE *but without recognition.*)

GORDO We are Britons all, Sir.

N.

MINIST Yes, yes. We are all fighting shoulder to shoulder, though I
ER. expect the realisation of it has hardly touched you yet.

GORDO My only brother was killed a few weeks ago in Gallipoli,
N. Sir.

MINIST Dear, dear. A sad business that. I'm sorry for that, my lad.
ER.

GORDO (*Beginning to be desperate.*) And that is one reason why, Sir,
N. I am so anxious to ask your help for my scheme of
international—

(VARLIE *meanwhile has very quietly slipped round so as to*
be on the front of the piano, within reach of coffee cup.)

MINIST (*Putting up his hand and gently interrupting.*) Now don't
ER. talk about schemes, young man. This is my recreation hour.
Seeing you carries me back to when I was a young chap
myself. My father was one of the old school and sent me
round the world to finish my education.

(*VARLIE'S right cheek now faces LOVEDAY, she gazes at it,
starts with amazed half recognition, for the top half of the
scar is visible.*)

MINIST I remember very well going to New Zealand—and seeing its
ER. pink and white terraces. Ah! They were wonderful,
wonderful.

GORDO They must have been, Sir (*his heart beginning to sink into*
N. *his boots*).

MINIST Yes, of course. They were destroyed before you could have
ER. seen them. A terrible volcanic outburst that! Incredible. Why
those great pink and white terraces looked as though no
power on earth could destroy them. So beautiful they were
too! So beautiful. Like coloured marble that had been spun
into lace cascades by magicians. Well, well, *sic transit
gloria mundi!* (*He shakes GORDON'S hand.*) I'm glad to have
had this little talk with you, Mr. Hyde. These pleasant
meetings help to link up the Empire. Good-bye. Good Luck.

(*Meanwhile, through the last part of this conversation,
VARLIE has taken out the Green Jade Carving, seen in Act
II., from his pocket. LOVEDAY recognises it and shows tense
anxiety and suppressed excitement. VARLIE glances stealthily
round the room, and sees that no one is looking at him, for
LOVEDAY pretends not to see him; she then turns her head
just in time to see him drop a drop of the poison into the
coffee cup on the piano, and quickly to turn away, his back
to the group, and go to another picture, hanging down right
front of the piano. VARLIE calmly pretends to be absorbed in
examining the picture. LOVEDAY is for a moment weak with
amazement and anxiety, and is evidently hesitating as to*

what course to follow, by the time the MINISTER says, “Good-bye, good luck.”)

GORDO Good-bye, Sir, thank you. (*Desperate.*) And may I come and
N. see you in office hours about my scheme? It is very
important, it—is a series of clauses for an international
arrangement which will wipe German Militarism and all
other militarism off the earth—it—

MINIST If you *must* send it—and I really ask you not to, I am
ER. deluged with other people’s ideas—if you *must* send it, my
secretary will attend to it. Good-bye.

*(GORDON steps back very dejected. The MINISTER turns, takes
up his coffee cup and says a word to the DUCHESS.)*

MINIST And now for our chat, my dear.

ER.

*(He raises the coffee cup, about to drink slowly. LOVEDAY
springs forward and dashes the cup from his hand, spilling
the coffee. [NOTE.—Better have a brown carpet so that the
successive stains of a long run won’t show.] The DUCHESS
and MINISTER look amazed.)*

LOVED (*Panting but quietly.*) That man, that man there!

AY.

*(Points at VARLIE, who is now in the corner between the
footlights, the piano, and the MINISTER’s group. Very
unostentatiously he digs the jade piece into the earth of pot
and has barely covered it by this time.)*

Hold him, Gordon, hold him.

*(GORDON literally hurls himself on VARLIE and, before he has
time to turn, has his two arms pinned from behind. The two
men struggle. The MINISTER looks bewildered. Hearing the
struggle the evening-dress-clad detective near the curtains
comes forward hurriedly and helps GORDON. They succeed in
holding VARLIE.)*

DUCHES For God's sake don't have a scene in public.

S.

(She runs across room and rings repeatedly. MAID comes in by door right.)

DUCHES *(To MAID.)* Draw those curtains *instantly* and stand by them.

S. Don't let anyone in, not anyone unless I tell you.

(The MAID hurries to obey and draws the heavy velvet curtains, shutting off the alcove from the main drawing room and stations herself by them.)

MINIST Dear, dear, what is this all about! Why it is a clergyman!

ER. isn't it? What on earth are they handling a clergyman in this fashion for? Why, Smithers man, you are to guard me, not to assist a young ruffian in mauling a reverend gentleman.

SMITHE *(Puzzled, half relaxing hold on VARLIE)* I'm sure, Sir, I don't

RS. know—

LOVED Don't, *don't* leave him! For God's sake hold him.

AY.

DUCHES What *on earth* is this outrageous fracas about? Loveday, I'm

S. *amazed!* The Rev. Dr. Chapman is an American whom I know and respect. Let him go at once, Smithers. And you, Mr. Hyde, you outrageous humbug!

LOVED Don't! *(She goes quickly up to VARLIE, pulls his beard with*

AY. *one hand, and it comes off.)*

(Amazement and consternation of all.)

LOVED Yes, I thought so! Look, Gordon, see that scar on his cheek,

AY. that little triangular red scar! But anyway you must know his face now, it is VARLIE!

VARLIE. How the devil—What does all this mean! You attack the Minister of Peace! I am the Rev. Dr. Chapman, as you well know, Duchess. If I choose to wear a false beard till my own grows because I desire to follow John the Baptist's example,

though alas late in life, is *that* any crime? Why don't you go round among your guests and arrest the ladies with false hair. *They* intend to attract and deceive while I but symbolise my belief in the Nazarene vows.

(He seems to be making an impression on the DUCHESS and the MINISTER.)

LOVED No! Hold him, he's dangerous. Hold him till I can tell you
AY. all!

GORDO Sure, Loveday, *I'll* hold him, even if Mr. Smithers won't.
N.

LOVED Oh, but you both must. Listen. The reason I spilt the coffee
AY. was that he had put poison in it!

MINIST *(Incredulous.)* Poison? Poison!
ER.
DUCHES
S.

LOVED Yes, poison. A deadly, secret poison, made from the karaka
AY. nut. It would never have been detected, never! A few hours later you would just have had a stroke and died! Of course he knows how dreadfully important you are.

MINIST Bless my soul. Are you raving or am I dreaming, young
ER. lady. How do you know this—this amazing thing?
DUCHES Fiddlesticks—tush—but, good God.
S.

LOVED I saw him do it.
AY.

VARLIE *(Putting on a superior air.)* Can you really even *listen* to
- such an absurd charge against one of my cloth?
CHAPM
AN.

LOVED I can prove it. You will find on him a green carved jade hei-
AY. tiki, it has a secret recess in which the poison was. It must be
on him. He couldn't swallow it, it's too big. Search him!

VARLIE (*Calmly.*) Search me, officer—if you are an officer—to
- satisfy the hysterical young lady and settle this absurd
CHAPM business once and for all.

AN.

LOVED Don't trust him. Have another man in to help. I charge him
AY. with attempted murder you know, murder of the most
important Cabinet Minister.

DUCHES Oh, Loveday, this is too awful (*She sits.*)
S.

MINIST I feel a bit shaken, perhaps I may sit too.
ER.

SMITHE This is serious you know. It had better be looked into if
RS. you'll excuse me, sir. I have some of my men outside. If you
would ring three times quickly, and then twice more, my
men will come in. (*Loveday rushes to the bell and does so.*)
Thank you, Miss.

VARLIE. Waal, if this isn't high comedy! But *most* unseemly! And to
think that it is in *your* house, Duchess, that I should be
served up with this nice little surprise party.
(*Enter two stalwart plain clothes men from door on right.*)

SMITHE Hold this gentleman firmly while we search his pockets.
RS. Excuse me, sir, but I think I ought to satisfy myself.

DUCHES I'm terribly distressed. I don't know what to think. I have
S. known Loveday since she was six and had freckles on her
nose, and she has *never* been hysterical.

LOVED (*Quietly.*) I'm not hysterical now there are two such nice
AY. strong men to hold Mr. Varlie.

MINIST *(Pathetically.)* Could I have some coffee do you think, my
ER. dear? I was really needing it before——

DUCHES Of course. This awful fracas must have exhausted you.
S.

MINIST *(Shaking his finger playfully at her.)* No fancy cakes now!
ER.

DUCHES There are none in my house, not even to-night. I may not be
S. clever, but I can see the obvious as well as most people, and
it is glaringly obvious that anyone whose hands are steady
enough to decorate foodstuffs can handle tools of more use
to the country. *(To MAID by curtains.)* Go and fetch some hot
coffee at once. I will stay by the curtains while you are gone.
Don't say one word to anyone, mind!
*(She goes out quickly through door right. Meanwhile
SMITHERS systematically searches all VARLIE's pockets. He
finds a revolver, which he lays out with an accusing look.)*

SMITHE That don't look like a clergyman, sir!
RS.

VARLIE. All Americans have those little pets on them. In the
backwoods I have had to have it cocked on to my
congregation so as to hold their attention!
*(Meanwhile LOVEDAY is quite quietly and unobtrusively
looking round the corner, front right, where VARLIE had been
standing before his arrest. The coffee comes in, the MINISTER
drinks it, the DUCHESS returns from the curtains and the
MAID takes up her place there again.)*

MINIST This is very painful, my dear, very painful. I'm sure I don't
ER. know what to think.

DUCHES We must wait and see.
S.

VARLIE.

Waal, Duchess, in a time like the present I quite understand your young girls getting hysterical. Don't let my position make you feel bad. I bear no malice. It is my duty and my pleasure to turn the other cheek!

(LOVEDAY stands gazing curiously at the palm, down right, near where VARLIE was. The smooth green moss is broken through in one place, and rough earth shows.)

SMITHE *(Rising.)* There is no jade ornament too large for him to
RS. swallow on him that I can see.

VARLIE. Naturally! It grieves me that you should be so inured to deception, young man, that you should doubt my word.

MINIST There, there. It was all a fancy. But you and I and the
ER. Duchess can forgive a pretty girl more than this, can't we,
Mr., Mr.——

VARLIE. Dr. Chapman, sir. Now your myrmidons can unhand me, I reckon.

(SMITHERS hesitates to give the order.)

LOVED Don't! It's not settled. Look at this.
AY.

(SMITHERS comes forward and looks at pot as she indicates.)

SMITHE I see nothing there, Miss.
RS.

LOVED The earth has been disturbed here—look, the rest of the pot
AY. is covered with moss.

DUCHES Oh, Loveday, Loveday. The gardener has pulled up a weed, I
s. suppose. Pulling up weeds always does disturb the moss.
Even the Government knows that.

LOVED Gordon, Mr. Smithers—haven't you a penknife one of you?
AY. Dig just there for me, please do.

VARLIE.

(*Gets suddenly restive in his keepers' hands.*) This is the limit! This beats everything. She put it there herself.

SMITHE (*Looking at him keenly.*) Put it there? You said there wasn't
RS. anything just now.

VARLIE. I have had enough of this. (*To the two holding him.*) Let me go, you monkey-faced jumbos. (*To SMITHERS.*) I'm due at our Embassy. You can do your agricultural work as well when I've gone.

SMITHE (*Now suspicious of him.*) We'll just see first if there is
RS. anything in this plant.

VARLIE. She did it herself. She simply put something in herself!

LOVED (*Spreading out her hands.*) Look! I've got white kid gloves
AY. on! I *couldn't* have done it without leaving earth on them!
and there isn't a grain!

MINIST (*Leans forward intently interested.*) She is a bright girl that. I
ER. call that clever.

DUCHES Clever, yes. But not witty! She lost an opportunity of saying,
S. "I have the proof at my finger tips."

MINIST (*Chuckling.*) No case! The white gloves of a Judge on
ER. circuit!

DUCHES Good! Ha, ha!
S.

LOVED Look at *his* hands. Look!
AY.

(*VARLIE closes his hands [which are gloveless] and clenches his nails in.*)

VARLIE. By gum, you don't insult me like this!

SMITHE Please open your hands, sir.
RS.

VARLIE. I won't, damn you.

SMITHE You had better, sir.

RS.

VARLIE. I dropped a coin in a flower bed this afternoon! I have some earth in my nails anyway. *(He half opens his hands reluctantly.)*

(ALL lean forward to see. Two fingers are stained and there is earth in two or three of the nails.)

SMITHE You'd have washed your hands if what you say about

RS. dropping a coin is true before coming here, sir. Hold him well, men. Yes, Miss. I'll dig this pot up for you.

(He digs with his penknife, all wait breathlessly, in a minute the green jade ornament appears. He wipes it with his handkerchief, holds it out to LOVEDAY.)

SMITHE Is that it, Miss.

RS.

LOVED *(Eager.)* Yes, yes, that is it!

AY.

MINIST *(Coming forward to look at it.)* Dear, dear! Fancy! I said

ER. Loveday wasn't hysterical.

DUCHES

S.

SMITHE That looks as though the young lady was right. You've had a

RS. narrow escape, sir!

VARLIE. That don't amount to shucks! What does that prove. There is only wild talk. I tell you I'm known at the American Embassy, I'm known to the Duchess here. You can't begin to prove I ever saw that green trumpery. The only thing you've got against me is that I wore a false beard! *(Sneers.)* Bring that up against an American citizen and a minister of religion and you would look queer in the Law Courts!

LOVED And you are known to me—to us. To both Mr. Hyde and me.

AY. You were Mr. Varlie in New Zealand.

GORDO Yes, Varlie, there's no mistaking you! You bought the
N. freehold of my Station and all my sheep and I'm not likely to forget it.

LOVED And you travelled all over New Zealand, selling things
AY. under the name of Varlie, and you wouldn't be pretending to be somebody else and a clergyman too, if you were honest. Besides (*scornfully*), I saw you buy that special secret poison from Roto, the old Maori, and you made very special enquiries about its use, too!

SMITHE (*As though recollecting something.*) Varlie—Varlie—New
RS. Zealand. The secret service particular warned me against a man called Varlie who has been hauling in a lot of freehold in New Zealand under various names, and travelling for German American firms. We had lost track of him. (*Joy spreading over his face.*) You don't mean to say he is John Varlie! Not John Varlie, Miss?

LOVED Yes, yes.

AY.

GORDO That's the name I've known him under in New Zealand for
N. months.

SMITHE My, men! We have got a haul. Well, ladies, the man is safe
RS. now, anyway. There is no need to bother you any more to-night.

DUCHES Cleverness seems to get an appropriately solid result,
S. Loveday?

SMITHE You are staying here, Miss? No? Your address, please.

RS.

(*He takes out a note book, she tells her address [a mumble and dumb show].*)

And yours, sir? (GORDON *does the same.*)
(*Meanwhile the MINISTER looks from one to the other, turns to DUCHESS.*)

MINIST He is evidently really a dangerous man! But a *clergyman*
ER. too! What an outrage to the cloth. That's the kind of thing to make atheists.

SMITHE (*Snapping his note book and turning quickly.*) He is no
RS. clergyman. A very dangerous man, sir. It is all a pretence too about his being an American. He is an out and out German, sir, and I make no doubt the young lady was right about his attempt on your life, sir. I expect you have had a narrow escape. We won't trouble you any further to-night. Take him off, men. I've got all the addresses. Good-night, ladies—good-night, sir, good-night, sir. (*Goes out after VARLIE, led by the men, unresisting now.*)
(LOVEDAY and GORDON *look at each other. DUCHESS subsides into sofa by the MINISTER.*)

DUCHESAs I said, even London is an adventure for the right man.
S. (*Fans herself.*) Loveday, come here.

MINIST (*Rises and shakes her hand, keeps it and pats it.*) My dear
ER. young lady, my dear young lady. The service you have done me is too great for thanks. You may command me—always. And I hope I may often have the happiness of serving you. But please give me something to do at once. What can I do for you?

LOVED Oh, there is one thing you can do for me, if only you will!
AY. Will you!

MINIST An-y-thing you like to ask, my dear, if it is humanly
ER. possible. What is it?

LOVED Please, oh please, let Mr. Hyde tell you about his wonderful
AY. International plan.

MINIST Of course, of course! So he is a friend of yours, is he?
ER.

GORDO (*Coming forward.*) I have that great honour, sir.
N.

GORDO (*Takes out sheaf of papers.*) If there was a Super-Parliament
N. constituted as I suggest Prussian Militarism, all Militarism,
is not only defeated now, but for ever! It is plucked out by
the roots, but not at the ruinous cost of imposing militarism
on all other nations. Oh, there's so much. (*Hesitates.*)

LOVED (*Breaking in, her voice almost chanting, like one inspired, its*
AY. *notes resembling those used by her at the close of Act I.*)
And Militarism is met, not by the weakness of a too trusting
idealism but by force controlled by intelligence. Law is
devised with behind it international force, which shall
protect the nations, as law backed by civil force protects
each man and woman in Britain.

(*HYDE starts, gazing intently at her set inspired face and
seems to recognise her voice. He stretches out a hand,
withdraws it, and whispers in awed voice.*)

HYDE. My queen! My vision. It is *she*! (*Sits as though entranced.*)

LOVED (*Does not notice him, but continues uninterruptedly.*) And
AY. the nation which will not come into this council of nations
proclaims itself an outlaw, an aggressor, a planner of evil,
and it inscribes its own doom, for law that is outraged takes
vengeance implacable.

(*There is a pause, she relaxes—smiles.*)

MINIST My dear—I must think.
ER.

LOVED (*Holding out her hands to him appealingly.*) You are the
AY. most powerful man in England, it is for you to initiate this
new era, of international safety and peace. Whatever the
terms of an ordinary peace, militarism will spring up again

to ravage the world. Let Britain lead in this new enlargement of law and freedom, for this is the only way to bring *security* to the world.

MINIST (*Very seriously.*) I will think about it, my dear.

ER.

DUCHES (*Returning to her normal.*) If that is cleverness it makes me
s. a little dissatisfied with mere wit.

MINIST (*To HYDE.*) Have your suggested constitution typed out,
ER. young man, and bring it to Downing Street the day after tomorrow. I'll send you a card with the hour. Your address?
(*HYDE hands him a card.*) I'll try to get the Prime Minister interested. Good-night.

LOVED How splendid.

AY.

MINIST Good-night, my dear, good-night. If you leave it very long
ER. before I see you again, I'll have to send for you. Heaven guard you, my dear.

(*To DUCHESS.*) I must say good-night. I have long outstayed my time.

DUCHES Let me see you off my premises. I only pray there are no
s. more adventures for you on them. I hope exterminated dangers leave rest behind them. (*They go off back centre together, the FOOTMAN pulls curtain apart to let them out and follows them. Faint strains of music are heard from distant room.*)

LOVED (*Sits on sofa, looks at GORDON with a rapt gaze.*) Your
AY. chance, the world's chance, has come!

GORDO (*In awe-struck voice, tenderly. He stands half stooping*
N. *before her.*) And you, you are not only my friend but my Goddess, my vision! Your look just now—your wonderful voice when you were speaking to the Minister a little ago. It

was you that night in the woods—you I have been adoring,
and from you I have been drawing my inspiration!

LOVED (*Softly.*) It was I in the woods. Chance gave me a moment's
AY. inspiration! which you worked into reality.

GORDO (*Half kneels before her.*) I know my love can be nothing at
N. all to you—I am not a fit mate for you. But let me go on
kneeling to you! Don't spurn me.

LOVED (*Slowly.*) Why are you so sure your love is nothing to me?
AY.

GORDO (*As though blinded by a sudden shaft of light in the*
N. *darkness.*) Oh! It can't be that it is anything to you?

LOVED Your love is everything to me.
AY.

*(Slowly he advances, with almost incredulous rapture. They
kiss.)*

CURTAIN.

BY THE SAME AUTHOR.

PLAYS OF OLD JAPAN: THE “NŌ”

BY MARIE C. STOPES AND
PROFESSOR JOJI SAKURAI

PREFACE BY BARON KATO

The Times says: “*The Sumida River* is a little play which, even in translation, one feels to be of great beauty and intolerable pathos. Dr. Stopes has written a lucid and serviceable introduction on the ‘Nō’ plays, which deserve the study of every student of the drama.”

The Morning Post says: “The translators have chosen a rhythmic, simple, irregular verse, which isolates just that element of pure tragedy that underlies the native literary crust of ornament.... We are convinced that drawing-room and library will welcome her to their hearts.”

T.P.’s Weekly says: “We advise all who care for the drama to read this book. The effect may be compared to that of having the best work of Synge with an added national and religious interest.”

The Spectator says: “Dr. Stopes has made the ‘Nō’ and their history for the first time accessible to the ordinary reader ... there is pleasure to be got from them even by those who only read a translation of the poems.”

The Times (New York) says: “Dr. Stopes has placed the English reader under a debt of gratitude by her work on these exquisite lyric plays.”

The Athenæum says: “The author’s vivid and imaginative sympathy has really enabled her in some degree to communicate the incommunicable.”

W. HEINEMANN. 5/- net.

MAN OTHER POEMS & A PREFACE

BY

MARIE C. STOPES, D.Sc., Ph.D., F.R.S.L. Fellow of University College,
London.

“The title-poem, wherein is set forth with thoughtful earnestness and no little grace of language the changing aspects of man to the eyes of ripening womanhood, and ‘The Brother,’ a ‘true and unvarnished’ tragedy, deriving force from the very homeliness of its telling, stand out most clearly in a volume of which the dominating qualities are clearness of vision and a distinctive point of view.”—*The Athenæum*.

“DR. STOPES is by calling a fossil botanist, and her scientific training gives restraint and substance to all her verse. This is particularly noticeable in the longish poem which opens the book, tracing the changing image which man assumes in the mind of a growing girl—a difficult theme well treated from the personal point of view, and in graceful measured phrase. But there is no lack of emotion in her pages; she sings with enthusiasm of the joy of married love; and sometimes in a minor key of regret for old, dead loves. Her highest level, we think, is reached in ‘Tokio Snow’—a beautiful fancy expressed in stanzas which have a curious but very successful rhyme-scheme, and ‘Human Love,’ an impressive moment of spiritual reflection on the theme ‘Amantium irae.’”—*The Times*.

W. HEINEMANN. 3/6 net.

Women’s Printing Soc., Ltd., Brick St., Piccadilly, W.1.

Transcriber's Note

The following apparent errors have been corrected:

- p. 10 "GORDON Stop" changed to "GORDON. Stop"
- p. 30 "Iv'e" changed to "I've"
- p. 34 "blazing" changed to "blazing.)"
- p. 42 "anquished" changed to "anguished"
- p. 51 "ingenius" changed to "ingenious"
- p. 72 "stuft" changed to "stuff"
- p. 75 "luovely" changed to "lovely"
- p. 85 "VARLIE-CHAPMAN (*Calmly.*)" changed to "VARLIE-CHAPMAN. (*Calmly.*)"

The following are used inconsistently in the text:

now-a-days and nowadays

*** END OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK CONQUEST; OR,
A PIECE OF JADE; A NEW PLAY IN THREE ACTS ***

Updated editions will replace the previous one—the old editions will be renamed.

Creating the works from print editions not protected by U.S. copyright law means that no one owns a United States copyright in these works, so the Foundation (and you!) can copy and distribute it in the United States without permission and without paying copyright royalties. Special rules, set forth in the General Terms of Use part of this license, apply to copying and distributing Project Gutenberg™ electronic works to protect the PROJECT GUTENBERG™ concept and trademark. Project Gutenberg is a registered trademark, and may not be used if you charge for an eBook, except by following the terms of the trademark license, including paying royalties for use of the Project Gutenberg trademark. If you do not charge anything for copies of this eBook, complying with the trademark license is very easy. You may use this eBook for nearly any purpose such as creation of derivative works, reports, performances and research. Project Gutenberg eBooks may be modified and printed and given away—you may do practically ANYTHING in the United States with eBooks not protected by U.S. copyright law. Redistribution is subject to the trademark license, especially commercial redistribution.

START: FULL LICENSE

THE FULL PROJECT GUTENBERG™ LICENSE

PLEASE READ THIS BEFORE YOU DISTRIBUTE OR USE THIS WORK

To protect the Project Gutenberg™ mission of promoting the free distribution of electronic works, by using or distributing this work (or any other work associated in any way with the phrase “Project Gutenberg”), you agree to comply with all the terms of the Full Project Gutenberg License available with this file or online at www.gutenberg.org/license.

Section 1. General Terms of Use and Redistributing Project Gutenberg electronic works

1.A. By reading or using any part of this Project Gutenberg electronic work, you indicate that you have read, understand, agree to and accept all the terms of this license and intellectual property (trademark/copyright) agreement. If you do not agree to abide by all the terms of this agreement, you must cease using and return or destroy all copies of Project Gutenberg electronic works in your possession. If you paid a fee for obtaining a copy of or access to a Project Gutenberg electronic work and you do not agree to be bound by the terms of this agreement, you may obtain a refund from the person or entity to whom you paid the fee as set forth in paragraph 1.E.8.

1.B. “Project Gutenberg” is a registered trademark. It may only be used on or associated in any way with an electronic work by people who agree to be bound by the terms of this agreement. There are a few things that you can do with most Project Gutenberg electronic works even without complying with the full terms of this agreement. See paragraph 1.C below. There are a lot of things you can do with Project Gutenberg electronic works if you follow the terms of this agreement and help preserve free future access to Project Gutenberg electronic works. See paragraph 1.E below.

1.C. The Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation (“the Foundation” or PGLAF), owns a compilation copyright in the collection of Project Gutenberg electronic works. Nearly all the individual works in the collection are in the public domain in the United States. If an individual work is unprotected by copyright law in the United States and you are

located in the United States, we do not claim a right to prevent you from copying, distributing, performing, displaying or creating derivative works based on the work as long as all references to Project Gutenberg are removed. Of course, we hope that you will support the Project Gutenberg mission of promoting free access to electronic works by freely sharing Project Gutenberg works in compliance with the terms of this agreement for keeping the Project Gutenberg name associated with the work. You can easily comply with the terms of this agreement by keeping this work in the same format with its attached full Project Gutenberg License when you share it without charge with others.

1.D. The copyright laws of the place where you are located also govern what you can do with this work. Copyright laws in most countries are in a constant state of change. If you are outside the United States, check the laws of your country in addition to the terms of this agreement before downloading, copying, displaying, performing, distributing or creating derivative works based on this work or any other Project Gutenberg work. The Foundation makes no representations concerning the copyright status of any work in any country other than the United States.

1.E. Unless you have removed all references to Project Gutenberg:

1.E.1. The following sentence, with active links to, or other immediate access to, the full Project Gutenberg License must appear prominently whenever any copy of a Project Gutenberg work (any work on which the phrase “Project Gutenberg” appears, or with which the phrase “Project Gutenberg” is associated) is accessed, displayed, performed, viewed, copied or distributed:

This eBook is for the use of anyone anywhere in the United States and most other parts of the world at no cost and with almost no restrictions whatsoever. You may copy it, give it away or re-use it under the terms of the Project Gutenberg™ License included with this eBook or online at www.gutenberg.org. If you are not located in the United States, you will have to check the laws of the country where you are located before using this eBook.

1.E.2. If an individual Project Gutenberg electronic work is derived from texts not protected by U.S. copyright law (does not contain a notice indicating that it is posted with permission of the copyright holder), the work can be copied and distributed to anyone in the United States without paying any fees or charges. If you are redistributing or providing access to a work with the phrase “Project Gutenberg” associated with or appearing on the work, you must comply either with the requirements of paragraphs 1.E.1 through 1.E.7 or obtain permission for the use of the work and the Project Gutenberg trademark as set forth in paragraphs 1.E.8 or 1.E.9.

1.E.3. If an individual Project Gutenberg electronic work is posted with the permission of the copyright holder, your use and distribution must comply with both paragraphs 1.E.1 through 1.E.7 and any additional terms imposed by the copyright holder. Additional terms will be linked to the Project Gutenberg License for all works posted with the permission of the copyright holder found at the beginning of this work.

1.E.4. Do not unlink or detach or remove the full Project Gutenberg License terms from this work, or any files containing a part of this work or any other work associated with Project Gutenberg.

1.E.5. Do not copy, display, perform, distribute or redistribute this electronic work, or any part of this electronic work, without prominently displaying the sentence set forth in paragraph 1.E.1 with active links or immediate access to the full terms of the Project Gutenberg License.

1.E.6. You may convert to and distribute this work in any binary, compressed, marked up, nonproprietary or proprietary form, including any word processing or hypertext form. However, if you provide access to or distribute copies of a Project Gutenberg work in a format other than “Plain Vanilla ASCII” or other format used in the official version posted on the official Project Gutenberg website (www.gutenberg.org), you must, at no additional cost, fee or expense to the user, provide a copy, a means of exporting a copy, or a means of obtaining a copy upon request, of the work in its original “Plain Vanilla ASCII” or other form. Any alternate format must include the full Project Gutenberg License as specified in paragraph 1.E.1.

1.E.7. Do not charge a fee for access to, viewing, displaying, performing, copying or distributing any Project Gutenberg works unless you comply with paragraph 1.E.8 or 1.E.9.

1.E.8. You may charge a reasonable fee for copies of or providing access to or distributing Project Gutenberg electronic works provided that:

- You pay a royalty fee of 20% of the gross profits you derive from the use of Project Gutenberg works calculated using the method you already use to calculate your applicable taxes. The fee is owed to the owner of the Project Gutenberg trademark, but he has agreed to donate royalties under this paragraph to the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation. Royalty payments must be paid within 60 days following each date on which you prepare (or are legally required to prepare) your periodic tax returns. Royalty payments should be clearly marked as such and sent to the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation at the address specified in Section 4, "Information about donations to the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation."
- You provide a full refund of any money paid by a user who notifies you in writing (or by e-mail) within 30 days of receipt that s/he does not agree to the terms of the full Project Gutenberg™ License. You must require such a user to return or destroy all copies of the works possessed in a physical medium and discontinue all use of and all access to other copies of Project Gutenberg™ works.
- You provide, in accordance with paragraph 1.F.3, a full refund of any money paid for a work or a replacement copy, if a defect in the electronic work is discovered and reported to you within 90 days of receipt of the work.
- You comply with all other terms of this agreement for free distribution of Project Gutenberg™ works.

1.E.9. If you wish to charge a fee or distribute a Project Gutenberg™ electronic work or group of works on different terms than are set forth in this agreement, you must obtain permission in writing from the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation, the manager of the Project

Gutenberg™ trademark. Contact the Foundation as set forth in Section 3 below.

1.F.

1.F.1. Project Gutenberg volunteers and employees expend considerable effort to identify, do copyright research on, transcribe and proofread works not protected by U.S. copyright law in creating the Project Gutenberg™ collection. Despite these efforts, Project Gutenberg™ electronic works, and the medium on which they may be stored, may contain “Defects,” such as, but not limited to, incomplete, inaccurate or corrupt data, transcription errors, a copyright or other intellectual property infringement, a defective or damaged disk or other medium, a computer virus, or computer codes that damage or cannot be read by your equipment.

1.F.2. LIMITED WARRANTY, DISCLAIMER OF DAMAGES - Except for the “Right of Replacement or Refund” described in paragraph 1.F.3, the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation, the owner of the Project Gutenberg™ trademark, and any other party distributing a Project Gutenberg™ electronic work under this agreement, disclaim all liability to you for damages, costs and expenses, including legal fees. YOU AGREE THAT YOU HAVE NO REMEDIES FOR NEGLIGENCE, STRICT LIABILITY, BREACH OF WARRANTY OR BREACH OF CONTRACT EXCEPT THOSE PROVIDED IN PARAGRAPH 1.F.3. YOU AGREE THAT THE FOUNDATION, THE TRADEMARK OWNER, AND ANY DISTRIBUTOR UNDER THIS AGREEMENT WILL NOT BE LIABLE TO YOU FOR ACTUAL, DIRECT, INDIRECT, CONSEQUENTIAL, PUNITIVE OR INCIDENTAL DAMAGES EVEN IF YOU GIVE NOTICE OF THE POSSIBILITY OF SUCH DAMAGE.

1.F.3. LIMITED RIGHT OF REPLACEMENT OR REFUND - If you discover a defect in this electronic work within 90 days of receiving it, you can receive a refund of the money (if any) you paid for it by sending a written explanation to the person you received the work from. If you received the work on a physical medium, you must return the medium with your written explanation. The person or entity that provided you with the defective work may elect to provide a replacement copy in lieu of a refund. If you received the work electronically, the person or entity providing it to

you may choose to give you a second opportunity to receive the work electronically in lieu of a refund. If the second copy is also defective, you may demand a refund in writing without further opportunities to fix the problem.

1.F.4. Except for the limited right of replacement or refund set forth in paragraph 1.F.3, this work is provided to you 'AS-IS', WITH NO OTHER WARRANTIES OF ANY KIND, EXPRESS OR IMPLIED, INCLUDING BUT NOT LIMITED TO WARRANTIES OF MERCHANTABILITY OR FITNESS FOR ANY PURPOSE.

1.F.5. Some states do not allow disclaimers of certain implied warranties or the exclusion or limitation of certain types of damages. If any disclaimer or limitation set forth in this agreement violates the law of the state applicable to this agreement, the agreement shall be interpreted to make the maximum disclaimer or limitation permitted by the applicable state law. The invalidity or unenforceability of any provision of this agreement shall not void the remaining provisions.

1.F.6. INDEMNITY - You agree to indemnify and hold the Foundation, the trademark owner, any agent or employee of the Foundation, anyone providing copies of Project Gutenberg™ electronic works in accordance with this agreement, and any volunteers associated with the production, promotion and distribution of Project Gutenberg™ electronic works, harmless from all liability, costs and expenses, including legal fees, that arise directly or indirectly from any of the following which you do or cause to occur: (a) distribution of this or any Project Gutenberg work, (b) alteration, modification, or additions or deletions to any Project Gutenberg work, and (c) any Defect you cause.

Section 2. Information about the Mission of Project Gutenberg

Project Gutenberg is synonymous with the free distribution of electronic works in formats readable by the widest variety of computers including obsolete, old, middle-aged and new computers. It exists because of the

efforts of hundreds of volunteers and donations from people in all walks of life.

Volunteers and financial support to provide volunteers with the assistance they need are critical to reaching Project Gutenberg's goals and ensuring that the Project Gutenberg collection will remain freely available for generations to come. In 2001, the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation was created to provide a secure and permanent future for Project Gutenberg and future generations. To learn more about the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation and how your efforts and donations can help, see Sections 3 and 4 and the Foundation information page at www.gutenberg.org.

Section 3. Information about the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation

The Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation is a non-profit 501(c)(3) educational corporation organized under the laws of the state of Mississippi and granted tax exempt status by the Internal Revenue Service. The Foundation's EIN or federal tax identification number is 64-6221541. Contributions to the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation are tax deductible to the full extent permitted by U.S. federal laws and your state's laws.

The Foundation's business office is located at 41 Watchung Plaza #516, Montclair NJ 07042, USA, +1 (862) 621-9288. Email contact links and up to date contact information can be found at the Foundation's website and official page at www.gutenberg.org/contact

Section 4. Information about Donations to the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation

Project Gutenberg™ depends upon and cannot survive without widespread public support and donations to carry out its mission of increasing the number of public domain and licensed works that can be freely distributed in machine-readable form accessible by the widest array of equipment

including outdated equipment. Many small donations (\$1 to \$5,000) are particularly important to maintaining tax exempt status with the IRS.

The Foundation is committed to complying with the laws regulating charities and charitable donations in all 50 states of the United States. Compliance requirements are not uniform and it takes a considerable effort, much paperwork and many fees to meet and keep up with these requirements. We do not solicit donations in locations where we have not received written confirmation of compliance. To SEND DONATIONS or determine the status of compliance for any particular state visit www.gutenberg.org/donate.

While we cannot and do not solicit contributions from states where we have not met the solicitation requirements, we know of no prohibition against accepting unsolicited donations from donors in such states who approach us with offers to donate.

International donations are gratefully accepted, but we cannot make any statements concerning tax treatment of donations received from outside the United States. U.S. laws alone swamp our small staff.

Please check the Project Gutenberg web pages for current donation methods and addresses. Donations are accepted in a number of other ways including checks, online payments and credit card donations. To donate, please visit: www.gutenberg.org/donate.

Section 5. General Information About Project Gutenberg electronic works

Professor Michael S. Hart was the originator of the Project Gutenberg concept of a library of electronic works that could be freely shared with anyone. For forty years, he produced and distributed Project Gutenberg eBooks with only a loose network of volunteer support.

Project Gutenberg eBooks are often created from several printed editions, all of which are confirmed as not protected by copyright in the U.S. unless a

copyright notice is included. Thus, we do not necessarily keep eBooks in compliance with any particular paper edition.

Most people start at our website which has the main PG search facility:
www.gutenberg.org.

This website includes information about Project Gutenberg, including how to make donations to the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation, how to help produce our new eBooks, and how to subscribe to our email newsletter to hear about new eBooks.